פירוש הגר״א על מגילת אסתר

The Vilna Gaon on Megillas Esther

A Complete English Rendition

Including the Commentary

Al Derekh HaPeshat — On the Level of Plain Meaning
Al Derekh HaRemez — On the Level of Allusion

With notes from

Be'er Avraham — R' Avraham ben HaGRA
Pirush HaRaDaL — R' David Luria

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Preface

This volume presents the complete commentary of the Vilna Gaon (Rabbi Eliyahu of Vilna, 1720–1797) on Megillas Esther, rendered into English for the first time in its entirety.

The Gaon's commentary operates on two distinct levels:

- **Al Derekh HaPeshat** (הפשט דרך על) — the straightforward interpretation, dealing with the historical narrative, the political dynamics, and the revealed miracles of the Purim story.
- **Al Derekh HaRemez** (הרמז דרך על) — the allusive interpretation, in which the Gaon reads the Megillah as an allegory for the soul's battle against the *yetzer hara* (evil inclination), the structure of prayer, and the hidden spiritual architecture of redemption.

The remez layer is one of the Gaon's most remarkable achievements in biblical commentary. He maps the entire Megillah onto the daily order of prayer (*seder ha-tefillah*), revealing how each event in the Purim narrative corresponds to a stage in the Jew's daily spiritual ascent.

Also included are notes from R' Avraham ben HaGRA (*Be'er Avraham*), who supplements his father's terse comments with expanded explanations, and from R' David Luria (*Pirush HaRaDaL*), who provides cross-references and clarifications.

Sources:

- Primary Hebrew text: AlHaTorah.org digital edition
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- Translation: Rendered into English with attention to scholarly accuracy and readability

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 1

Megillas Esther: Chapter 1

The Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA)

Verse 1

"And it was in the days of Achashverosh; he is the Achashverosh who reigned from Hodu (India) to Kush (Ethiopia), seven and twenty and a hundred provinces."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

He is Achashverosh: [The verse specifies "he is"] because there was another Achashverosh, the father of Darius the First, the Mede, as it says: "In the first year of Darius the son of Achashverosh, of the seed of the Medes" (Daniel 9:1), and he also reigned. For there were always kings of Media. However, regarding what is thought (Megillah 11a) that there were only two kings of Media and Persia who ruled over the entire world—those were indeed only two [Cyrus and this Achashverosh]. But Achashverosh the father of Darius only ruled over Persia and Media alone, and Darius began the reign over the entire world. Therefore, it writes here, **"He is the Achashverosh who reigned from Hodu…"** to emphasize that the first Achashverosh only ruled over Persia and Media. **"From Hodu to Kush"**: The Sages said (Megillah 11a), "Just as he ruled over Hodu and Kush, so he ruled from one end of the world to the other."

Seven and twenty and a hundred: It is said in the Midrash: one hundred over the dry land and twenty-seven over the islands of the sea. This is what is meant by the verse: "And King Achashverosh imposed a tax on the land and the islands of the sea" (Esther 10:1)—behold, one hundred on the land and twenty-seven in the sea.

Province (Medinah): This refers to a very large city, a royal capital. This is what the Sages meant (Megillah 2b) when they said, "Granted,

a *medinah*… is a city surrounded by a wall from the days of Joshua bin Nun." That is, a large city fortified since the time of Joshua. This is also the meaning of the Gemara regarding *mezuzot* (Yoma 11a): "Both the gates of towns (*ayarot*) and the gates of provinces (*medinot*)." Rashi explains there: "Such as the land of Hagar [Hungary] which is surrounded by a wall." This is a great difficulty—that the Gemara would speak specifically of the land of Hagar. But according to what I have written, it works well: every large royal city has several unwalled towns (*perazim*) that belong to it, and the [metropolis] is called a *medinah*.

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

The Midrash says: "To what can this be compared? To a king who had seven sons, and the youngest was a hundred *revi'it* [a measure of volume], and he loved him more than all of them." **"Until Kush"**: This refers to the *klipot* (husks/impure forces) of death. This is the meaning of the statement (Megillah 11a) that he ruled from one end of the world to the other. As it says (Berachot 59b), "Bless the Lord, O my soul" corresponds to five worlds. The beginning of man's birth is the "end of the world," and he is called a "small world" (*olam katan*) until his end. One Sage says [Hodu and Kush] were adjacent, and another says they were distant. This refers to the days of man: "between a night and a night" [i.e., life is fleeting].

Seven and twenty and a hundred provinces: In the beginning, he ruled over seven. This refers to when a child enters school at age seven (Baba Batra 21a). It is known that the Torah is the "spices" [antidote] for the *yetzer hara* (evil inclination), as it says: "I created the *yetzer hara*, and I created the Torah as its spice" (Kiddushin 30b). Therefore, he [the *yetzer hara*] rules at first for seven years because there is nothing to hinder him, and the child does not yet have a *yetzer tov* (good inclination). Afterward, he rules over twenty, for they say to him [the youth] that he is not yet liable for [Heavenly] punishment. Meanwhile, he is overcome by great rebellions in his lowly traits and desires. Even though the language "one hundred" follows "twenty-seven," he [the *yetzer hara*] rules over all one hundred years.

The word **"Medinah"** (province) hints at the year (*shanah*), for just

as there are many levels of government in a province, so there are many different types of incitements by the *yetzer hara* for all the days of the year. As it says (Zohar III:267a), there are 365 damaging prosecutors [corresponding to the solar year]. This is as it says: "A man's *yetzer* overcomes him every day" (Sukkah 52a). Regarding this, King Solomon said: "Rejoice, young man, in your youth" (Ecclesiastes 11:9)—this is the claim of the *yetzer hara*, that you are not yet liable for punishment. But know that for all these things, God will bring you to judgment. This "Achashverosh" [the *yetzer hara*] does not leave him until the end. The 127 years of Sarah's life are the secret of the "Correction of the Head" (*Tikkun HaRosha*).

Verse 2

"In those days, when King Achashverosh sat on the throne of his kingdom, which was in Shushan the capital."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

When King Achashverosh sat on the throne, etc.: The Midrashim (Esther Rabbah; Tanchuma) explain that this throne was a replica of the throne of King Solomon, peace be upon him. He made another like it because he was unable to sit upon the original [due to its miraculous nature]. They worked on it for three years, and they could only complete it in Shushan. Because it was exceedingly large, as explained in *Targum Sheni*, they could not bring it to Babylon, where all the kings before him had resided. Therefore, he went and resided in Shushan. This is the meaning of **"When King Achashverosh sat"** specifically—for all the kings before him sat in Babylon. **"On the throne of his kingdom which was in Shushan"**: Meaning, on that specific throne which was in Shushan.

The Capital (Habirah): The explanation is: it is a great fortress within a royal city for the residence of kings, their ministers, and the leaders of the people, like Zion in Jerusalem. This is "Birah," as in "The *birah* (palace / temple) which I have prepared" (I Chronicles 29:19). And as it says, "And I was in Shushan the capital, which is in the

province of Elam" (Daniel 8:2). The explanation is that Elam is the royal city itself, and Shushan is the fortress within it.

The text writes this to show the greatness of the Blessed Name, who orchestrated events to perform a miracle for Israel. Since Mordechai was already in Shushan—as it says, "There was a Jewish man in Shushan" (Esther 2:5), meaning he was already there—the Holy One, Blessed be He, brought about circumstances to lead Achashverosh to Shushan to reside there. Therefore, the Sages said (Megillah 19a) that one must read the entire Megillah. For ostensibly, why do we need to know the power of Achashverosh? However, in every single verse, it tells of the greatness of the miracle. But the miracle was through **"Hester Panim"** (the hiding of the Divine Face); that is, He orchestrated it to happen through the way of nature, and not like it was in Egypt with a "strong hand and an outstretched arm." Therefore, we mention the Exodus from Egypt every day and on every Festival and Shabbat, but we do not mention this miracle [daily], even though it was a transition from death to life, whereas Egypt was from slavery to freedom.

This is the meaning of the Gemara (Megillah 11a): "'And He extended kindness to us before the kings of Persia'—when was this? In the time of Haman." Ostensibly, this is puzzling. The matter is as the Sages said (Chullin 139b): "Where is Esther hinted at in the Torah? As it is written, 'And I will surely hide (*haster astir*) My face on that day' (Deuteronomy 31:18)." This statement is difficult to understand; why did they ask where Esther is in the Torah more than any other righteous people through whom miracles were performed? The answer is that a miracle in the Land of Israel is not such a novelty. Therefore, Hanukkah is not as [unique] a miracle as Purim, even though it was a very great miracle, because it occurred during the time of the Temple. When they asked "Where is Esther in the Torah," the meaning is: where is it hinted that even during *Hester Panim*—that is, in exile—He performs such a great miracle for us? They answered: "And I will surely hide (*haster astir*) My face"—meaning even in the time of the hiding of the Face, I will send Esther.

According to this, we understand the Gemara (Chagigah 5b) where a heretic said to Rabbi Joshua ben Hanania: "A people from whom their Master has turned His face away." Rabbi Joshua showed him:

"His hand is still outstretched over us." The explanation is that the heretic cited "I will surely hide My face" according to its simple meaning [abandonment]. But Rabbi Joshua told him that nevertheless, His hand is outstretched over us, as hinted by the word "Astir," which alludes to Esther—that He performed miracles for us, but they were in "hiding" (*hester*). This is "He extended kindness to us before the kings of Persia," for the Holy One, Blessed be He, performed such a great miracle for us. They said this was in the days of Haman, and therefore it was a greater miracle than Hanukkah, but it was through *Hester Panim*.

They gave a parable: To a king who had an only son. The ministers were jealous of him because they saw the king's great love for him. In time, the son sinned against his father, and the father banished him to the forest. The son thought his father had abandoned and forgotten him. But the father, in his mercy for his son, was afraid that the wild beasts of the forest or the ministers who hated him would harm him. What did he do? He sent his servants who minister to him into the forest, but told them not to let his son know of this, so that he would repent for the sins he had committed. In time, a bear came upon him, and one of the father's servants came and saved him; the son thought it was a coincidence. Afterward, a minister who was one of his enemies came, and one of the father's servants stood up and saved him from his hand. The son understood: how could it be that such frequent coincidences always happen? He realized his father had done this, and his father's love was fixed in his heart, and he returned in complete repentance (*teshuvah sheleimah*).

So too, the Holy One, Blessed be He, sent us into exile and was afraid that the "harsh bears" [the nations] would harm us. He sent with us His ministering servants and performs miracles for us through them, but it is through *Hester Panim*. However, Mordechai, Esther, and their generation saw and understood that this was from Heaven, and they accepted the Torah upon themselves with great love (Shabbat 88a).

According to what I have written, we understand what the Sages said (Chagigah 13b): "What Ezekiel saw, Isaiah saw; but Ezekiel is like a villager who saw the king, and Isaiah is like a city-dweller who

saw the king." The explanation is: Isaiah saw [prophecy] in the Land of Israel, and everyone believed him; he did not need to give them a sign. But Ezekiel was like a "villager"—that is, in exile and outside the Land—and they would not believe that he saw the *Shechinah* (Divine Presence) in exile until he gave them signs. Once they saw that their beloved status with the Holy One, Blessed be He, remained, and that He sent His ministers and servants to guard them, love and affection were increased in their hearts.

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

When the King sat: After his mind became settled. For a child cannot speak until he tastes the taste of grain [sin], for the Tree of Knowledge was wheat [according to one opinion], and therefore knowledge enters him. Therefore they said (Sukkah 42b): "Once he can eat a *kazayit* (olive-sized piece) of grain, they distance him from his mother's impurity," for he begins to be nourished by desires and *klipot* that "eat." Therefore, "in the third year of his reign"—this is when the child is weaned and his mind is settled.

When the King sat: For the four legs of the Throne of the Chariot of Impurity are the four groups that do not receive the Face of the *Shechinah* [which are: scoffers, liars, flatterers, and slanderers]. The throne itself is the body, and the *yetzer hara* sits upon it as the "king of desire." Regarding this, it says "When the King sat… on the throne of his kingdom," for he brought into the heart of man all the aforementioned traits, and then he acts.

Shushan: As it says in the Zohar, "king and blood" (*melech vedam*) is compared to a rose (*shoshannah*) which is red and white. The dwelling of the *yetzer hara* and its forces is in the "king and blood," and therefore it is forbidden to eat them.

The Capital (Habirah): For this is the primary dwelling (*dirah*) of the *yetzer hara* and its forces.

Verse 3

"In the third year of his reign, he made a feast for all his ministers and his servants; the army of Persia and Media, the nobles and the ministers of the provinces were before him."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

In the third year of his reign: The explanation is: this refers back to "When King Achashverosh sat on the throne… in Shushan." This occurred in the third year of his reign, as stated above, that the work on the throne was delayed for three years, and in the third year of his reign, he sat upon it. At that time, **he made a feast for all his ministers and his servants.**

The explanation of **"Minister" (*Sar*)** is one who rules over towns and all that belongs to him, ensuring there is no injustice and judging among the nations. **"Servants" (*Avadim*)** are those who minister to the king and see the king's face; anyone who needs to come to the king to request something does so through them. This is the meaning of the Gemara: "Is Chanina greater than you? He said to her: No, but he is like a servant before the king, and I am like a minister before the king." Now, this Gemara is not understood—what did he answer to her question? But according to what I have written, it works well: the "Minister" is the master of the Torah, and the "Servant" is one who is constantly occupied with the needs of the Jews and with prayers. These are the "Early Pious Ones" (*Chassidim Rishonim*) who used to pray with great intention (*kavanah*). This is the meaning of "Is Chanina greater than you in Torah?" To this, he answered her: "No, rather I am like a minister, for I am an expert in all the chambers of the Torah more than him. But he is like a servant before the king, who can come at any time and the king fulfills his request." This is "for all his ministers"—the rulers over all he had—and "his servants"—those who minister to him.

The army of Persia and Media, the nobles (*partemim*): These are the dukes of the royal seed of Persia and Media. He made a feast for all their armies because they were of his own nation; therefore, he made it before their entire army. He also needed them because they were "those who sat first in the kingdom." But for the other provinces, he

did not make it for all their armies, but only for the **"ministers of the provinces."** These were the royalty of the province, but compared to him, they were all merely "ministers," for he ruled over them, as it says, "Are not all my ministers together kings?" (Isaiah 10:8).

Before him: Since his ministers and servants come first, as they are close to him, he counts his ministers and servants first. However, the ministers of the provinces were "sitting before him"—meaning near him. As the Sages said (Megillah 12a), he would appease the distant ones [first], but those close to him he could appease whenever he wanted.

In the Gemara (Megillah 12a), they noted that once it writes "Persia and Media" and [elsewhere] it writes "to the kings of Media and Persia." They said: "They made a condition with each other, etc." The reason that regarding "the kings of Media and Persia," Media is written first, while in the rest of the Megillah, Persia is written first, is because Achashverosh was from Persia; therefore, since Media was only a province (*eparchy*), he wrote Persia first. But at the end of the Megillah, in the "Book of Chronicles," it is written "to the kings of Media and Persia" because the Chronicles were from earlier, and originally Media ruled first, as it says, "And Darius the Mede received the kingdom" (Daniel 6:1). Therefore, it writes "to the kings of Media and Persia."

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

He made a feast: He brings desire into his heart. **For all his ministers, etc.:** These are the external forces (*chizonim*) appointed over the other traits. For the "monarchy" is the gateway to all evil traits. The divisions of the traits are "ministers," and the "surroundings" are "servants." Over every year there is one appointee, and likewise over every month. This is "and the ministers of the provinces were before him"—those who stand and minister. As the Midrash says on the verse "And there was a quarrel between the herdsmen of Abram's cattle and the herdsmen of Lot's cattle" (Genesis 13:7)—that they are the assistants of the *yetzer hara*.

The army of Persia and Media: These are the two daughters of Lot, as mentioned in Zohar III:115b. The *yetzer hara* only rules through two

powers of the soul: the "Thought" (*Machshavah*) and the "Arouser" (*Mit'orer*). These correspond to the *Nefesh* and *Ruach* which are in the part of the "Changeable" and the "Imagination." They are called Persia (*Paras*) and Media (*Madai*) because *Paras* is from the language of "a slice" (*perusah*), corresponding to desire, as it says: "No man dies with half his desire in his hand." *Madai* hints at the lust for money, as the GRA says in his *Likkutim* on the statement (Baba Kamma 103a) "He must follow him even to Media"—that money is of no account to him. This power extends to the trait of Honor. These are the "two daughters of Lot" who come to mislead him, as it says: "On the first night the elder came, and on the second night the younger."

Verse 4

"When he showed the riches of his glorious kingdom and the honor of his excellent majesty many days, even a hundred and eighty days."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

When he showed, etc.: The fact that it says "when he showed," and also that it writes "many days" which seems redundant, and also the matter of the many days of the feast—this is not [immediately] understood. The matter is that Nebuchadnezzar had 1,080 treasures, and he hid them by the Euphrates River. The Holy One, Blessed be He, revealed them to Cyrus because he commanded the building of the Temple, and Achashverosh inherited them. The purpose of the feast was to show his wealth so that he would find favor in their eyes. However, it is not the way [of kings] to simply call people and show them; so he made a feast, and when their hearts were merry, he went with them to show them.

He showed them six treasures every day, as the Sages said. These are the six specified in this verse: (1) **Riches**, (2) **Glory**, (3) **Kingdom**, (4) **Honor**, (5) **Excellence**, (6) **Majesty**. Behold, six treasures. Thus, he needed 180 days [to show all 1,080 treasures at a rate of six per day]. Therefore, he made a feast for 180 days. The explanation of the verse **"When he showed"** is: during those days that he showed them the

wealth—all six treasures every day—for "many days," he made a feast during those days. And how many days were they? One hundred and eighty days.

As for what is said, **"the riches of his glorious kingdom and the honor of his excellent majesty"**: The explanation is as it says, "This is My name and this is My memorial" (Exodus 3:15). The Sages said (Pesachim 50a): "Not as I am written am I read; I am written with *Yud-He* and read with *Aleph-Dalet*." This is because the name *Havayah* [Y-H-V-H] indicates His Essence, while *Adonai* indicates His Kingship, for He is the Master (*Adon*) of all the earth. Therefore, He is called by *Adonai*, which indicates His Kingship, for it is not the way to call a king by his personal name, but by his royal title. Therefore, He is called *Adonai* and not *Yud-He*.

So too here: **"Majesty" (*Gedulato*)** is his essence, and **"Kingdom" (*Malchuto*)** is his reign. Regarding "Kingdom," it writes **"Glory" (*Kavod*)**, and regarding "Majesty," it writes **"Excellence" (*Tiferet*)**. This is because the distinction is like that between a servant and a son. A son prides himself (*mitpa'er*) in the essence of his father; a son whose father is a great sage prides himself in the essence of his father, that he is the son of that sage. As it says, "The excellence (*tiferet*) of children are their fathers" (Proverbs 17:6). But a servant has no benefit from the essence [of the master]; rather, if the master is a ruler and minister, the servant has the benefit that people honor him or fear him because "the servant of a king is like a king" (Shevuot 47b). Therefore, regarding "Majesty," which is the essence, it says "Excellence" (*Tiferet*), and regarding "Kingdom," it says "Glory" (*Kavod*).

This is what the Gemara meant when it said he wore the Priestly Garments. For regarding the Priestly Garments, it is written "for glory and for excellence" (Exodus 28:2). This means that in the Priestly Garments, his essence was visible because they saw that he bore the Holy Name upon him and had to be holy and pure; also, the greatness of his rule and wealth was visible, for regarding one hook (*karas*), the Sages said they gave a thousand gold dinars. The text says that he [Achashverosh] also showed them his essence and his kingdom, just as the High Priest's essence and rule were visible (for the High Priest was immediately below the king in rank).

When it writes **"the riches" (*et osher*)**, the word *et* implies inclusion/multiplicity meaning the abundance of the glory of his kingdom. So too, **"the honor" (*et yekar*)**. The "glory of his kingdom" is what comes from his reign, which is silver and gold. His "essence"—that is, what he inherited from his ancestors who hid it—refers to precious and very dear stones. Therefore, regarding "Kingdom," he said "Riches," and regarding "Essence," he said "Honor" (*Yekar* - preciousness). And as for why it says *et* and *et* [twice], it is because they are six [treasures], three included within three.

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

When he showed, etc.: This refers to the "Garments of the Soul." **He wore the Priestly Garments:** This means he intended that the primary honor should be because he was a ruler and judge in the land, for that is "Glory." This is what is meant here by "the glory of his kingdom." But this was not fitting for him, as it says, "Anyone who dresses in the cloak of a Torah scholar [when he is not one]…" (Baba Batra 58a). It is written, "If a matter is hidden from you… you shall come to the Priest" (Deuteronomy 17:8), and "They shall teach Your laws to Jacob," and "They shall seek Torah from his mouth." This is their statement: "He wore the Priestly Garments"—it is written here "Glory and Excellence" and it is written there [regarding the Priestly Garments] "for glory and for excellence." All his eyes were set on [usurping] this glory and excellence.

Many days: The Sages said (Vayikra Rabbah 19:5): "'And if a woman has a discharge… many days'—'days' means two, 'many' means three." Why are they called "many"? Because they are days of suffering. It is known that the year is 365 days and a quarter. They said (Shabbat 89a): "Deduct half for the nights," leaving 183 days. Three of them are Rosh Chodesh Elul, Rosh Hashanah, and Yom Kippur [and three fasts instead of Shabbat], which are "many days" of suffering for the *yetzer hara*. There remain 180 days.

Verse 5

"And when these days were fulfilled, the king made for all the people who were found in Shushan the capital, from great to small, a feast of seven days, in the court of the garden of the king's palace."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And when [these days] were fulfilled… who were found in Shushan: The explanation is: because at that time he had come from Babylon (for all the kings sat in Babylon, as I wrote on verse 2), but he came [to Shushan] because of the throne. Therefore, he called all the people dwelling in Shushan "those who were found," because he found them there.

In the court of the garden of the king's palace (*bechatzer ginat bitan hamelech*): The explanation is: it is customary to build a house (*bitan*) within the king's garden where they go to enjoy themselves. In front of the garden is the court (*chatzer*). He seated them there, in the court before the garden, inside of which was the king's palace. The verse says that even in the "court of the garden" there was a pavement of porphyry, marble, pearl, and precious stone.

The matter is that the Holy One, Blessed be He, made three worlds: (1) The Upper World, where the "partition" of the Holy One is, and where the souls of the great righteous—called "Sons of the Ascent" (*Bnei Aliyah*)—ascend. (2) The second world is the Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden*), where the Holy One enters to enjoy Himself with the righteous. (3) The third is This World (*Olam HaZeh*). This World is called a "court" (*chatzer*), as the Sages said: "Prepare yourself in the corridor (*prozdor*)…" (Avot 4:16). This is what is written: "In the court of the garden"—which is in This World.

The Sages said (Megillah 12a): "Whoever was fit for the court, to the court; whoever was fit for the garden, to the garden." That is: the wicked in the court, the righteous in the garden, and the "Sons of the Ascent" in the palace (*bitan*). (There is no room here for the question of the Tosafot, who asked: "Do we not avoid casting jealousy at a meal?" See there). In a Baraita it was taught: "He seated them in the court and opened two entrances for them, one to the garden, etc." The explanation is that He placed choice in the hand of man; "in the way

a person wishes to go, they lead him" (Makkot 10b). Furthermore, it said: "He seated them in the court and it did not hold them; he seated them in the garden and it held them." The explanation is based on the Midrash regarding what Elijah said to the Holy One: "I have been very zealous (*kanno kinneti*)…" (I Kings 19:10). The Holy One answered him: "Go… and anoint Elisha… in your stead." The Holy One said: "The world can no longer endure you." This is "He seated them in the court"—which is This World—"and it did not hold them," and "He seated them in the garden"—meaning the world cannot hold them because the world is not worthy of them, so He seated them in the garden, in the Garden of Eden.

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

And when these days were fulfilled: These are Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. Afterward, he took 18 [days]. "The King made"—He opened it for Himself. For previously, even though Achashverosh said [he would do as he pleased], it was in his power to do *teshuvah*.

For all the people who were found in Shushan the capital, etc.: These are the aforementioned traits, the four legs of the throne with all their armies. The rest of the traits are the "seven days" [of the feast].

A wise king… a foolish king: The *yetzer hara* is a "wise king" in that he accustoms a person to evil traits from youth, for "the dwellings of impurity" are always with him and he can bequeath them to him. And he is a "foolish king" because if a man takes it to heart, the *yetzer hara* will not rule over his evil traits. If he did not accustom him to [evil] traits, he would not be able to leave them, for habit becomes nature.

A feast of seven days: For they said, "From Shabbat to Shabbat." The commentators explain this refers to the seven days of mourning [for the soul]. Regarding this, the Sages said: "Seven days of feasting" to prepare the light for his soul. But this one [Achashverosh] made all the days into "feasts" [of sin].

In the court of the garden of the king's palace: For in the Garden of Eden there are two levels. One group sits inside in the palace (*bitan*), and one group walks among the rows, which is the "garden" (*ginat*). This World is the "court" before This World [the World to Come]. "Pre-

pare yourself in the corridor so that you may enter the banquet hall." But the wicked spend all their days in the corridor. This is "the court of the garden of the palace of the king"—besides the King Himself.

Verse 6

"There were hangings of white, fine cotton, and blue, embroidered with cords of fine linen and purple wool, upon silver rods and columns of marble; the couches were of gold and silver, upon a pavement of variegated marble, and white marble, and mother-of-pearl, and precious stones."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

White, fine cotton (*Chur karpas*), etc.: The explanation is: it is the way of nobles that they do not have benches and chairs to sit on; rather, they sit for eating upon couches (*mitot*). Since they have nothing to lean the body against, they make something like rollers with high columns inside them, and they spread cloths over the columns—that is, from column to column—and tie them to the columns from the outside, and they lean themselves against the columns. This is what it means by **"white, fine cotton, and blue"**—the cloths were of white and fine cotton, etc., and they were tied with cords of fine linen. This is **"fastened" (*achuz*)**—meaning tied with cords of fine linen and purple wool.

And the columns stood upon silver rods (*gelilei chesef*): The explanation is that the rollers upon which the columns stood were of silver, and the columns themselves were of marble, which is *shesh*. **The couches were of gold and silver**, and the floor was of five types of precious stones, each one different from the other and varied. The verse tells us all this to show the status of the righteous in the World to Come. For "one hour of [spiritual] bliss in the World to Come is better than all the life of This World" (Avot 4:17). We do not know how great the power of the World to Come is, so the verse tells us the greatness of This World, so that we may understand from it the World to Come.

Verse 7

"And they gave them drink in vessels of gold, the vessels being diverse one from another, and royal wine in abundance, according to the bounty of the king."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And they gave them drink… diverse: The explanation is: anyone who drank from a cup would not drink from that cup again; rather, they would give him a different cup. **Royal wine:** Wine that is very good and precious, which only kings drink. **In abundance (*rav*):** That they gave much wine. **According to the bounty of the king (*keyad hamelech*):** The explanation is: just as they give the king much wine so that he may choose for himself and drink, so they gave to each and every person.

Verse 8

"And the drinking was according to the law; none did compel; for so the king had appointed to all the officers of his house, that they should do according to every man's pleasure."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And the drinking was according to the law (*kadat*): It is explained in the Gemara (Megillah 12b): "According to the law of the Torah." What is the law of the Torah? That eating is more than drinking. Now, the Gemara is not understood at all, and Rashi distanced himself from explaining it as referring to the Altar. It seems the explanation is as follows: They said (Avot 6:4), "This is the way of the Torah: eat bread with salt and drink water by measure." We say a "measure" (*mesurah*) is one thirty-third of a *log*, which is very small. But for eating, they did not give us a fixed amount; rather, every man as he wishes. This is why it says [this]: because it was difficult—why does it not mention

"eating" in the Megillah, but writes everything as "drinking"? To this it says that in the Megillah it is written "and the drinking was according to the law"—according to the law of the Torah, as it says "eat bread with salt and drink water by measure." So too here, in his feast, eating was more than drinking. And if his drinking was so abundant, you can understand from this how his eating was.

None did compel: The explanation is: because it is the way at a feast that each person pressures his fellow to drink quickly because he also needs to drink. But here, because there were "vessels diverse from one another" [so many cups], therefore it writes "none did compel." Or, as it says in the Midrash, at all other feasts they would compel people to drink, but here there was no compulsion because "so the king had appointed, etc."

Every man's pleasure (*ish va'ish*): In the Midrash (Esther Rabbah) they said: The Holy One, Blessed be He, said: "You said to do according to the pleasure of 'man and man' (*ish va'ish*); I will give you two men whose pleasure you will fulfill: Mordechai, the 'Jewish man' (*ish Yehudi*), and Haman, the 'adversary and enemy man' (*ish tzar ve'oyev*)." This is what the Gemara means: "*Ish va'ish*—Mordechai and Haman." The verse tells us how the Holy One, Blessed be He, orchestrates events and turns the heart of man to perform a miracle. For his [Achashverosh's] intention was to fulfill the pleasure of the lowliest of the low, yet afterward he decreed upon his wife, who was a king's daughter, to bring her naked against her will, and then he killed her because she broke his haughty spirit when he showed the glory of his kingdom, his power, and his wealth—and afterward, even his wife did not pay him heed.

Verse 9

"Also Vashti the queen made a feast for the women in the royal house which belonged to King Achashverosh."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

Also Vashti the queen: The explanation is: even Vashti's making of the feast was unnatural. For what need did she have for a feast? His feast was only to find favor in the eyes of the people so they would not rebel against him. But her feast, which was for women—there was no need for this at all, for who would rebel against her? Rather, the verse shows us how He orchestrates events to perform a miracle for Israel.

The royal house which belonged to King Achashverosh: The explanation is: the king has two chambers—one where he sits, and a second which is reserved only for the king and no other enters it. She made the feast inside the house reserved for King Achashverosh. The verse shows us that "before destruction comes pride" (Proverbs 16:18).

Verse 10

"On the seventh day, when the heart of the king was merry with wine, he commanded Mehuman, Biztha, Charvona, Bigtha, and Abagtha, Zethar, and Carcas, the seven chamberlains that served in the presence of Achashverosh the king."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

On the seventh day, when the heart of the king was merry with wine, etc.: In the Gemara (Megillah 12b) it asks: "Was his heart not merry with wine until now?" [It answers:] "The seventh day was Shabbat, when Israel eat and drink and occupy themselves with words of Torah, but at the feast of that wicked one, etc." Now, the Gemara is not understood—neither the question nor the answer. For what is the difficulty? Even on the seventh day the king's heart was merry with wine, and they were speaking at that time of matters of women, as explained; therefore he said to bring [Vashti]. Also, the answer is not understood at all—his joy was not because of Shabbat, so what do Israel have to do with this matter?

The matter is: they said in the Midrash (Zohar III:109a) that wherever it says "The King" without qualification, it refers to the Holy One,

Blessed be He. On this, they asked: "Was the heart of the King [God] not merry with wine until now?" Meaning, certainly the Holy One has no pleasure in their wine. It answers that "now it was Shabbat," and the heart of the King [God] was merry with the "wine" of Israel, who eat and drink and occupy themselves with words of Torah. But the idolaters eat and drink and occupy themselves with words of frivolity, and the Holy One has no pleasure in them at all. Even at the feast of that wicked one, these were saying "Persian women are beautiful" and those were saying "Median women are beautiful," etc. This was because Vashti made a feast for women in the royal house, and each one could hear the voice of his wife, and they were speaking about their wives.

Verse 11

"To bring Vashti the queen before the king with the royal crown, to show the peoples and the princes her beauty; for she was fair to look on."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

To bring… to show…: The explanation is: he said "to bring" without qualification, and the verse says "to show, etc." because she was of good appearance; therefore he wanted to show her. As for why it says "the peoples" first and then "the princes"—it is because the peoples sit near the entrance and the princes sit near the king; therefore he said "peoples" first because they would see her first as she entered.

Verse 12

"But the queen Vashti refused to come at the king's commandment by the chamberlains; therefore was the king very wroth, and his anger burned in him."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

But the queen Vashti refused, etc.: At first verse 9 it said "Vashti the queen." The explanation is that he said there [in his command] "Vashti the queen" to imply that originally she was a commoner and afterward became queen. But here it says **"The Queen Vashti"** first, to say that she was a queen first, even before she married Achashverosh. This is why he sent to bring "Vashti the queen"—referring to her status as the king's wife, while she herself was a commoner. But she replied that she was a king's daughter even before she married him.

Therefore was the king very wroth, and his anger burned in him: In the Gemara (Megillah 12b): "Why did it burn in him so much? Because she sent to him: 'Son of my father's stableman, etc.' " The explanation is: it is the way of a person that if he becomes angry and speaks the matter out, the anger subsides and does not "burn" in him. But here, even though he spoke and was very wroth, nevertheless "his anger burned in him." On this, the Gemara asks: "Why did it burn *in him*?"—specifically internally. On this they said she sent him "Son of my father's stableman"—and therefore it burned *in him*, for this he could not tell the ministers because it was a disgrace to him. He could only say that she did not come. This is "The king was wroth"—over what the chamberlains said publicly, that she refused to come; "and his anger burned in him"—over the words of disgrace that the chamberlains told him privately.

Verse 13

"Then the king said to the wise men, who knew the times—for so was the king's manner toward all that knew law and judgment."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

Then the king said to the wise men, who knew the times: The explanation is: there are two types of courts. One rules according to the strict line of the law, and one rules according to the "needs of the hour" (*hora'at sha'ah*), where it is sometimes necessary to lighten the

judgment and not follow the strict law—such as for a king or a great person. Even if the law dictates a certain way, because they are concerned for his honor, they lighten it for him.

Now, Achashverosh had a double trouble: he did not know what to do, for his desire was to save her because she was of great lineage and also a beauty like no other in the world, as the Sages said (Megillah 15a). However, he could not save her because he was afraid of the people, lest they rebel against him. Therefore, he asked the "wise men who knew the times"—meaning those who know every single time, when it is a "time" to be lenient, as I wrote above.

For so was the king's manner (*dvar hamelech*): The explanation is: for this reason, he did not judge her himself; rather, those who knew "law and judgment" would judge her. This is "for so was the king's manner"—meaning such was the law among them, that every matter of the king should be before all who know law and judgment. It says **"Law and Judgment" (*Dat vaDin*)** because a judge needs to know two things: (1) the Law (*Dat*), and (2) the Arguments (*Din*)—how to judge the case. This is the "Legislator" (*Mechokek*) who gives the law, and the "Judge" (*Shofet*) who sees how to judge. The giver of the law is the king, and the judges are the ministers, as it says, "Behold, a king shall reign for righteousness…" (Isaiah 32:1). This is what it says: "Law" is the statute, and "Judgment" is knowing how to judge.

Verse 14

"And the next unto him were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena, and Memucan, the seven princes of Persia and Media, who saw the king's face, and sat first in the kingdom."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

Who saw the king's face, etc.: Because they need to know the law and the judgment, therefore he spoke to those who always see the king's face and know the law. **Who sat first in the kingdom:** They are the judges of the people of the land.

Verse 15

"What shall we do unto the queen Vashti according to law, because she has not done the bidding of the king Achashverosh by the chamberlains?"

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

According to law, what to do with the queen Vashti: The explanation is: Achashverosh's desire was to save her, and therefore he said "with the *queen* Vashti"—meaning, with her who was the daughter of a great king. **Because she has not done the bidding of the king:** He only said that she did not do the bidding of the king—meaning she did not come—and he did not mention the disgrace, even though they knew of it, as will be explained later, with God's help. **By the chamberlains:** The explanation is: not in the presence of the king, but through others.

Verse 16

"And Memucan answered before the king and the princes: Vashti the queen has not done wrong to the king only, but also to all the princes, and to all the peoples that are in all the provinces of the king Achashverosh."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And Memucan answered: In the Gemara they said (Megillah 12b): "From here we see that a commoner jumps to the front." Ostensibly, it is difficult—how is it proven from here? Perhaps they were also speaking, but because his word was upheld, the text only wrote the words of Memucan. It seems their proof is from the fact that it is written **"before the king and the princes"**—for it is obvious that he spoke before the princes, so this is redundant. Therefore they said: "From here we see that a commoner jumps to the front"—meaning "before" implies *prior* [to the others].

For [not] against the king only: The explanation is: he did not say that if it were against the king alone he would not care. Rather, he saw that if they judged as equals, they would not put her to death because he saw that such was the king's will, and they would also flatter her. He [Memucan] also had married a woman greater than himself and his desire was to be rid of her. As it says in the Midrash, this Memucan is Haman, and it was a cause from Heaven so that he would prepare the salvation through himself. His desire was that the king himself should judge her, and then he would not be able to forgive her because he would fear the ministers. Therefore he said: "Not against the king alone, but against all the ministers"—meaning, it does not only affect him, but on the contrary, it affects the ministers. Therefore, let the king himself judge her. He said "against the ministers and against the peoples"—meaning against the ministers who are here, and against the peoples who are in all the provinces, later when they hear of it.

Verse 17

"For this deed of the queen will come abroad unto all women, to make their husbands contemptible in their eyes, when it shall be reported: The king Achashverosh commanded Vashti the queen to be brought in before him, but she came not."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

For this deed of the queen will come abroad: The explanation is: this refers to all the peoples after the deed of the queen becomes known to all women. And when will this be? **"When it shall be reported"**—meaning when the ministers afterward return to their homes and tell that the king said, etc., or the women of the nations hear of it and they too will despise their husbands.

Verse 18

"And this day shall the princesses of Persia and Media who have heard of the deed of the queen say the like unto all the king's princes. So shall there be much contempt and wrath."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And this day: The explanation is: all this will happen afterward when they hear the deed of the queen. Also **"this day"**—all the women of Persia and Media who sat with the queen and heard the deed of the queen—meaning what she said, "Son of my father's stableman"—they will say it to all the king's ministers who did not know this. **Much contempt and wrath:** Contempt for how she disgraced him and called him "son of a stableman," and wrath because she did not listen to the king's command.

Verse 19

"If it please the king, let there go forth a royal commandment from him, and let it be written among the laws of the Persians and the Medes, that it be not altered, that Vashti come no more before king Achashverosh; and let the king give her royal estate unto another that is better than she."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

If [it please the king] let there go forth a royal commandment, etc.: The explanation is: let him innovate two things today. (1) "Let there go forth a royal commandment"—meaning even a matter concerning the monarchy itself shall go forth from him, and he shall judge it himself. **And let it be written among the laws of Persia and Media, that it be not altered:** The explanation is: this [law] that the king shall be able to judge even what concerns himself. And regarding Vashti he said: **"That she come no more"**—meaning even if she now wants to come, they shall not let her. As for why he said they should write the punishment as "that she come no more" and not write that she be

killed—it is because his intention was for the sake of his own wife, as mentioned. If they wrote that she be killed, it would be of no use, for he [the husband] has no power to kill, as he has no authority for this; likewise, all of them have no authority to kill just because a wife does not do her husband's will. Therefore he said the punishment is "that she come no more," and everyone can do this. Consequently, she will be killed if she never comes again, for the king will have no need for her.

And let the king give her royal estate unto her companion: Meaning, one of similar lineage. And as for her being a beauty: **"unto another that is better than she"**—let the king marry one even more beautiful. He said **"and her royal estate"** (*umalchutah*) because she herself is not important, only her royalty; if so, it makes no difference, for whoever the king marries will be queen.

Verse 20

"And when the king's decree which he shall make shall be published throughout all his kingdom, for it is great, all the wives shall give to their husbands honor, both to great and small."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

And when the king's decree which he shall make shall be published: The explanation is: everyone will hear that the king can act on his own in all his kingdom, even in what concerns himself. **For it is great:** For this is a great thing, that the fear of the king will be greater upon them because he can judge by himself. He said this because the Holy One, Blessed be He, orchestrates events so that they would be able to hang Haman. For if the king could not judge a matter that concerned himself, they would not have been able to hang Haman until all the ministers agreed. Therefore, God brought it about that the king could judge by himself. **All the wives shall give honor to their husbands:** Through the vengeance taken against Vashti, they will give honor to their husbands. **From great to small:** The explanation is: whether he

is greater than his wife or even if he is smaller than his wife, as he [Achashverosh] was, as mentioned.

Verse 21

"And the saying pleased the king and the princes; and the king did according to the word of Memucan."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

The verse informs us here that the Holy One, Blessed be He, turns the heart of man. It "pleased the king" to kill her even though it was not his original will. And it pleased the princes, even though this was bad for them—for now the king would judge by himself even what concerned him and do everything according to his will, taking from them the power they held—nevertheless, it pleased them.

Verse 22

"For he sent letters into all the king's provinces, into every province according to the writing thereof, and to every people after their language, that every man should bear rule in his own house, and speak according to the language of his people."

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

Into every province according to the writing thereof, and to every people after their language: Regarding "province" it mentions "writing," and regarding "people" it mentions "language." This is because nations are divided by four things: writing, language, land (for every nation has its land), and clothing. Sennacherib confused all the nations (Mishnah Yadayim 4:4); he took those who dwelt in one province and settled them in another. The "writing" follows the province, but every nation speaks the "language" it spoke originally. Therefore, it is written regarding the province "writing"—meaning to the ministers

in the province, for Sennacherib did not exile the ministers. But to the people "after their language"—meaning it was necessary to write in the script of the province and the language of that nation which was now dwelling there.

With this, the difficulty raised by Ibn Ezra (Genesis 27:40) is answered. We say that the fourth exile is the exile of Edom, yet the Roman Empire is Kittim, and Edom was under the kings of Israel at the time of the Destruction. But according to what I have written, it works well: Sennacherib confused all the nations, and they had a tradition that Edom was settled in Rome.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 2

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther: Chapter 2

The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

(1) That which she had done and that which was decreed against her — In the Gemara (Megillah 12b): "Just as she had done, so it was decreed against her." **The explanation is:** It was difficult for them [the Sages] that it is written "which was decreed against her," which implies [a decree] from Heaven, even though it might not have been appropriate to do so to her; and what is the meaning of the expression "decreed"? Therefore, they explained that "that which she had done" refers to Israel—just as she [Vashti] had done to Israel [forcing Jewish girls to work on Shabbos], so it was decreed against her from Heaven.

(2) Young virgins — "Young women" and not old ones; "virgins" and not those who had already had relations. And it uses the plural language, meaning all the young women who were of beautiful appearance from the entire city.

(3) And let the king appoint officers… and let them gather every

young woman, etc. — The explanation is: That the officers should gather from all the young women one girl from the best of them all, and afterward, even the best among them would be given into the hand of Hegai. **And let their ointments be given — The explanation is:** As they said in Tractate Ta'anit (31a): "The beautiful among them would say, 'Young man, lift up your eyes and see what you choose for yourself, for a woman is only for beauty'; the well-born among them would say, 'Young man, lift up your eyes and look at the family'; the ugly among them would say, 'Take your purchase for the sake of Heaven, provided that you crown me with gold [jewelry].' " Now, this is a wonder: if one wants to take a wife for the sake of Heaven, he should take the well-born! However, the matter is that a purchase made for an ulterior motive is not good, and in both [the beautiful and the well-born] there is an ulterior motive. But with the ugly ones, [who say] "crown me with gold and we will become pleasant," it will be for the sake of Heaven and we will also be beautiful. It emerges that the more a woman adorns herself, the more beautiful she is. For this reason, it says "and let their ointments be given from the king's house"—they were all equal. For if they had all adorned themselves on their own, they would not have known which one was of more beautiful appearance, for this one might adorn herself more and this one less.

(4) And let the maiden, etc. — The explanation is: One maiden from all the maidens. **Reign in the place of Vashti — The explanation is:** Memuchan had said "to her peer" (1:19), meaning one of noble lineage like her. But the king's attendants said "of beautiful appearance," for "what do I care about lineage? For whoever she may be, she will reign in the place of Vashti, and there is no practical difference regarding lineage." Similarly, they said "Vashti" and did not say "Queen Vashti."

(5) A Jewish man (*Ish Yehudi*) — In the Gemara they said (Megillah 12b): "He is called *Yehudi* [from Judah] and he is called *Yemini* [from Benjamin]." They answered: "He was crowned with his laws (*nimusin*)." Now, this Gemara is not [easily] understood and is very wondrous; are they not all called *Yehudim* (Jews), as is written in this Megillah many times? At first glance, it would seem that their difficulty stems

from the word *Ish* (man), which is a term for a prince or person of importance, as in "Are you not a man (*Ish*), and who is like you…" (I Samuel 26:15). But even this is not a difficulty, for one could say he was a prince. It appears that their difficulty is from the word *Ish* as mentioned, and that it appears twice. For the reason they are called *Yehudim* is because the Land of Israel was divided into Judah and the Galilee, and since those in the Galilee were exiled in the days of Sennacherib, only the tribe of Judah remained. Even though some from Benjamin and other tribes remained—whom Jeremiah brought back—since they all went into exile and only a few remained, they too were included in the tribe of Judah. This is what was difficult for them: "He is called *Yehudi*," implying he is now a prince over all of Judah, who are all of Israel called by the name *Yehudim*; and "he is called *Ish Yemini*," implying he was originally a prince when they were on their land, when each tribe was called by its own name. To this they answered that he was "crowned with laws," meaning with two crowns: he was originally a prince over the tribe of Benjamin, and afterward when they were exiled, he also became a prince over all the Jews, and his first title also remained. **Was in Shushan the capital — The explanation is:** Because he was there first, and Ahasuerus came because of him, as mentioned above (1:2); therefore it is written "He was (*Hayah*)." **The son of Jair, the son of Shimei, the son of Kish** — In the Gemara they said (Megillah 12b): "Son of Jair—who enlightened (*he'ir*) the eyes of Israel with his prayer; son of Shimei—for God heard (*shama*) his prayer; son of Kish—who knocked (*hikish*) on the gates of mercy." Now, this Gemara is a very exalted wonder: why did they expound thus? Could they not expound similarly on any name, even a hundred times? It appears that because in man there are four senses: sight, hearing, smell, and speech. Three of them are for the study of Torah: sight is to see the Written Torah; hearing is to hear the Oral Torah; speech is to teach others. But smell is not needed for Torah at all, but rather for the aspect of prayer, as it says, "a fire-offering, a pleasing aroma (*rei'ach nicho'ach*) to Hashem" (Leviticus 1:9). Mordechai represents the aspect of smell, as it says "pure myrrh (*mordechai*)" (Exodus 30:23), which the Targum renders as *mari dachia* [pure master], which is the aspect of prayer. Therefore they said that all these aspects were in his

prayer: "Jair"—that he enlightened the eyes of Israel, which is sight; "Shimei"—that He heard his prayer, which is hearing; "Kish"—that he knocked, which is speech. These four senses correspond to the four letters of the Name [Y-H-V-H]. This is why it says first "A Jewish man (*Ish Yehudi*)" and then "A Benjamite man (*Ish Yemini*)," as mentioned, for they are in the general and the specific.

(6) Who had been exiled from Jerusalem, etc. — It says "exiled" here three times: "who had been exiled from Jerusalem," "who had been exiled [with the exile]," "whom [Nebuchadnezzar] had exiled," to make known his love for the Land of Israel—that each time he returned to Jerusalem and was exiled three times. This is what they meant (Megillah 13a) that "he went into exile on his own," meaning by his own will he returned to the Land of Israel, and because of that, he was exiled a second time, and likewise a third time. And it uses the language of exile four times here to indicate that all four exiles will remember his redemption, as it is said, "and their memory shall not perish" (9:28). **With Jeconiah king of Judah** — To indicate his greatness, that he was a Benjamite yet he was the head among them, as it says "A Jewish man (*Ish Yehudi*)."

(7) Hadassah, she is Esther — The explanation is: Her name was "Hadassah," and the nations called her "Esther" after the name of the star *Istahar* [Venus], as stated in the Gemara (13a). And it says here that he was raising Hadassah, who is called Esther. In the Gemara, they [infer] from the fact that it mentions Hadassah at all, since she is called Esther throughout the Megillah, and they said her name was Esther because of her righteousness (*tzidkus*), to say that they understood immediately when she was born that she would be righteous. **His uncle's daughter, etc.** — It states here the reason that led to him raising her, and mentions three things: 1) She was his uncle's daughter. 2) She had no father or mother—meaning she never had a father or mother [even for a moment]. 3) She was of beautiful form and beautiful appearance—as will be explained later with Heaven's help. Regarding Esther, it says "beautiful form (*yefas to'ar*)," but when the king's servants spoke, they only said "good appearance (*tovas mareh*)." This is as it says, "I am black but comely" (Song of Songs 1:5). They said (Shir HaShirim Rabbah 1:35): "I am black in my deeds, but comely

in the deeds of my ancestors." Now, this is not understood at all. It appears there are two types of beauty: one who is beautiful in appearance (*mareh*), and one who is dark in appearance but whose limbs are beautiful—meaning they are in proper proportion, neither too long nor too short, such as the nose and other limbs. This is what is meant by "I am black"—even though I am black and have no good deeds, nevertheless I am beautiful in the "cut of the limbs," which are the commandments themselves that I perform like the righteous, even though I do not know their secret and intention. So too here: "beautiful form (*yefas to'ar*)" refers to the cut of the limbs, which correspond to the commandments; "beautiful appearance (*yefas mareh*)" refers to good character traits and the intention of the heart. Therefore Esther, who was a Jewess, possessed "beautiful form," the cut of the limbs corresponding to the commandments, and "beautiful appearance," which is good traits and a good heart. But the gentiles possess only "good appearance" [natural traits]. Therefore they [the servants] only said "good appearance." Mordechai, who saw in Esther the beautiful cut of limbs and also good appearance, understood she would be righteous in the performance of commandments and also a possessor of good traits, as it says "The recognition of their faces witnesses against them" (Isaiah 3:9); therefore he took her to himself as a daughter. **And at the death of her father and mother, etc.** — This is the timing; meaning, from when did he take her? At the death of her father and mother.

(8) And it came to pass, when the king's word and his decree were heard — The explanation is: At first, Esther was hiding herself. But afterward, when they saw they had not brought Esther, they went back and issued a decree (*das*) that anyone who has a young woman and does not bring her shall be put to death, as stated in the Midrash (Targum Sheni). Then she was revealed and they took her against her will. This is "the king's word"—which was the first command; and "his decree"—which was the law he established that if they do not bring her, they will be put to death. **And when [many maidens] were gathered, etc. — The explanation is:** And even this was only so that they would all be gathered. **Esther was taken** — Against her will, to show the greatness of her compulsion, that it was not by her desire.

(9) And the maiden pleased [him]… and she obtained kindness

— For a woman needs two virtues: 1) that she be of good appearance, and 2) that she find favor and kindness before him because she is pious (*chasidah*). This is what they said (Ketubot 17a): "A beautiful and graceful (*chasudah*) bride," as mentioned. **And he hastened, etc. — The explanation is:** Everything that needed to be given to her, he gave with speed, for he understood she would be queen. **And the seven maidens, etc. — The explanation is:** Those maidens given from the king's house to a queen, he gave to her immediately, for he understood she would certainly be queen. **To the best [part] of the house of the women — The explanation is:** He changed [her location] and gave her and her maidens a house better than all the other women, for they were the queen's maidens.

(10) Esther did not tell, etc. — The explanation is: For Mordechai had commanded her not to tell her people or her kindred. This was because she had been hiding herself from the king, and even after she was discovered, she did not go until they took her against her will. Mordechai was afraid they would kill her, her family, and her people, for they would say they do not wish to intermarry even with the king. Now the verse shows us the greatness of her righteousness: Mordechai only commanded her out of fear that they might kill her, yet she saw that they were treating her with great honor and not mentioning what had happened; nevertheless, "Esther did not tell." This is because "Mordechai had commanded her not to tell," and she kept Mordechai's command even though she knew the reason no longer applied.

(11) To know the welfare of Esther and what would be done with her — For Mordechai was distressed over two things: 1) He knew Esther was a great righteous woman, and the "good" of the wicked is evil to her, and she was greatly distressed by this; he was afraid she might fall ill from the greatness of the distress. 2) He was also distressed and afraid they might kill her because she had hidden herself and did not want to go, as mentioned. This is the meaning of "to know the welfare of Esther"—meaning if she is not ill; "and what would be done with her"—if they had not killed her.

The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

(5) A Benjamite man (*Ish Yemini*) — [The soul] is called "from the right," as it says "And you, go to the end… to the portion of the right" (Daniel 12:13), and as it says "A wise man's heart is at his right" (Ecclesiastes 10:2).

(7) And he was raising Hadassah — The explanation is: He raised the soul, not the body, so that it would not follow its lusts. "Hadassah" is the body in this world, and why is it called Hadassah? On account of the myrtle (*hadas*), as it says "and he stands among the myrtles" (Zechariah 1:8). **She is Esther** — For they [the nations] call her by the name of the moon (*Istahar*), for the righteous are called by the name of the moon, as is known. **For she had no father or mother** — As it says, "Who said of his father and mother, 'I have not seen them' " (Deuteronomy 33:9) [referring to the soul's detachment from worldly origins]. **And the maiden was of beautiful form, etc.** — Desirable above [to God] and pleasant below [to man]. **And at the death of her father and mother** — After she removed from herself all the traits of this world, then Mordechai took her to himself as a daughter.

(12) And when the turn of every maiden came, etc. — According to the plain meaning, there are superfluous words here that are not necessary at all. It appears they hinted to us in this regarding the soul, which is called a "maiden." **According to the law of the women — The explanation is:** The law of a woman is to give her twelve months for ornaments (Ketubot 57a). This means that every Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, a person returns in repentance and cries out "I have sinned, forgive me," and the Holy One, Blessed be He, in His great kindness and mercy, passes over his sins and iniquities. **The explanation is:** The iniquity itself is not erased but remains suspended [to see] if he will return in complete repentance, as I will write later; [if so] He will forgive, but if not, He will not forgive. Such is the judgment of the Holy One, Blessed be He: even though for a sin he commits later he might not be so deserving of that punishment, yet because of past sins, He punishes him. This is what is said: "If your children sinned against Him, He delivered them into the hand of their transgression" (Job 8:4). **The explanation is:** Even though they only committed a sin that was unintentional and it was not fitting to deliver them for that, He deliv-

ered them into the hand of the transgressions they already had, and now, because of the [new] sin, they were reckoned. This is what we say [in liturgy]: "Because of our sins and the iniquities of our fathers, the Temple was destroyed." **The explanation is:** Because of the iniquities of our fathers the Temple was destroyed, and now because of our sins—for which we might not be liable for such a result—nevertheless it is not rebuilt because they reckon our sins along with the iniquities of our fathers. This is why they wait for her a period of twelve months. **For so were the days of their ointments fulfilled — The explanation is:** The days in which they would cleanse (*yamriku*) themselves from transgressions. **Six months with oil of myrrh — The explanation is:** For the Holy One, Blessed be He, created everything in man for a purpose, except for the hair, which is superfluous; it corresponds to the permitted things that a person does not need to have. This is hinted at in the portion of "When you go out to war," as stated in the Zohar: "and she shall shave her head and do her nails" (Deuteronomy 21:12), which are the superfluities. This is why it says "six months with oil of myrrh." They said in the Gemara (13a): "What is oil of myrrh? *Stachis*, which removes hair." This means he should cast away superfluous desires for all six months. And for six months he should habituate himself in the commandments, which are positive and negative. This is "with perfumes," which are the positive commandments, and "with the ointments of women," which are the negative commandments—meaning he should cleanse himself so as not to commit transgressions. Thus he should habituate himself all year.

(13) And with this the maiden came, etc. — The explanation is: If he conducts himself thus all year—half in repentance and casting away desire and doing good deeds, and half in positive and negative commandments—afterward he can come to the King on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur to request, and they do not mention his first iniquities to him at all. **Whatever she would say would be given to her, etc. — The explanation is:** That the Holy One, Blessed be He, always fulfills the will of the righteous and does their desire, etc., and protects them. But not in this world; for Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa was a great righteous man and pious, yet he had nothing to eat except in the World to Come. Also, immediately after death, when one goes

from this world to the World to Come, many evil accusers stand on the way. One also needs to pass through Gehinnom, even a perfectly righteous person. But if he did as mentioned above, they protect him so that he is not harmed, Heaven forbid. This is "whatever she would say, etc., to come with her from the house of the women"—which is this world—"to the house of the King"—which is the World to Come.

Continuation of Peshat

(14) Guardian of the concubines — The explanation is: For she who had been intimate with the king was forbidden to all others, as it says Abishag the Shunammite was forbidden to Adonijah but permitted to Solomon. Therefore he did not send her to her home, but she remained in the hand of Shaashgaz and became a concubine. **She would not come again to the king, etc.** — For the virgins each had a set time of twelve months, but the concubines had no set time. "Unless he desired her and she was called by name"—for each one's name was written before the king.

(15) And when the turn of Esther came, etc. — As they said in the Midrash: " 'Your righteousness is like the mighty mountains, Your judgments are a great deep' (Psalms 36:7)—when the Holy One, Blessed be He, performs a miracle through a righteous person, when He mentions the righteous person He mentions his lineage; but when He performs judgment on a wicked person, He does not mention his lineage." Therefore it is written here "the daughter of Abihail the uncle of Mordechai, etc." **She requested nothing** — All this the verse shows us: the greatness of her compulsion, for every moment she was in distress over this. **And Esther was [obtaining favor] — The explanation is:** Even though she was constantly distressed and became greenish (*yerakrokas*) because of this, nevertheless "Esther obtained favor in the eyes of all who saw her." This is what they said in the Gemara (13a): "Esther was greenish." For at first glance it is puzzling, as it is written "and the maiden was of beautiful form and beautiful appearance." But according to what I wrote, it fits well: in truth she was of beautiful form, but because of the greatness of her distress she became greenish;

nevertheless, the Holy One, Blessed be He, gave her favor because a "thread of kindness" was drawn over her.

(16) And Esther was taken — By others, for even here she was under great compulsion. **It is the month of Tevet** — In this, the Holy One, Blessed be He, showed that He is the Cause of all causes, and He brought it about that it should be at the time when the nights are long and [the king] would increase in intimacy; through this, the two chamberlains of the king became angry, as they said in the Gemara (13b). **In the seventh year of his reign** — This shows us that Esther hid herself for three years, as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud (Yalkut 1053). For in the third year was the feast and then Vashti was killed, and she did not come until the seventh year of his reign. Perforce, they took her in the sixth year, and for twelve months she was being adorned; therefore she came in the seventh year.

(17) And the king loved Esther, etc. — The explanation is: Regarding a virgin, the concept of "a beautiful and graceful bride" applies, as mentioned above; therefore it is appropriate to say "favor and kindness (*chen v'chesed*) more than all the virgins." But regarding the women who were already there previously, it only writes "love," for presumably they were beauties whom he had taken while Vashti was still alive; presumably he chose the beautiful ones for himself. **And he placed the royal crown on her head — The explanation is:** He immediately placed the crown on her head and did not wait to see if he might find one more beautiful than her, for he said in his heart that there is none more beautiful than this one in the world. **And he made her queen in the place of Vashti — The explanation is:** She was in his eyes like Vashti, even though she was silent and he did not know her family, and she even said she did not know; nevertheless, she was in his eyes like Vashti, who was a daughter of kings.

(18) A great feast — The explanation is: An important feast, for the feast became very great in his eyes, like when people say of a person that he is "great"—he is not necessarily great in quantity but in quality. So this feast was in his eyes more important than the first feast, even though it was not as large in quantity, for the first was one hundred and eighty days. **For all his princes and servants, etc.** — Because she was very important in his eyes, he called it by Esther's name; there-

fore it says "Esther's feast." **And he made a release for the provinces** — Because he did not know from which family she came, he made a release for the provinces [hoping she would reveal it]. This is what is written later, that when he knew from which family she was, "King Ahasuerus placed a tax, etc." (10:1), as explained (Gemara 13a). **And he gave gifts — The explanation is:** Not only did he make a release, but he gave great and important gifts according to the king's bounty.

(19) And when the virgins were gathered a second time, etc. — The explanation is: Afterward they gathered all the remaining virgins to send them to their homes. They wrote this to show the greatness of Esther's righteousness, as will be explained. **And Mordechai sat in the king's gate — The explanation is:** To everyone he gave a release and gifts. And for Mordechai, who was a Jew, he nevertheless needed to do something great for him; for this, the king made him sit in the king's gate, meaning among the king's princes.

(20) Esther did not tell — The explanation is: Even though she saw she was great in the king's eyes and he was making releases for all the provinces for her sake, and she saw they were sending away all the virgins and he no longer desired them, and they also seated Mordechai among the king's princes—and certainly if he knew what he was to her [he would do more]—nevertheless, "Esther did not tell." Rashi explains: because Mordechai sat in the king's gate, he commanded her and urged her not to tell. **And the word (*ma'amar*) of Mordechai — The explanation is:** Even a light word.

(21) Of the guardians of the threshold — The explanation is: For the guardians of the threshold are three, as stated in the Gemara (23a); therefore it says "of the guardians of the threshold." In the Gemara it says they said: "Is my watch and your watch not [the same]?" Now, this is not understood. It appears that because they were great princes standing on guard, and they were three, they divided the three parts of the king's night. In that plot, two of them were involved, and they said: "Behold, we are two, and one must go to bring the poison and prepare it, and this requires much time, yet I must stand on guard." The second replied: "I will guard my watch and your watch." This is "and it was found"—they said they found him in a watch that was not his, for the second had gone to prepare the poison.

(22) In the name of Mordechai — She did not take the greatness for herself, but told the king in his name, because she understood that a miracle would arise from this.

(23) Before the king — To show the causes of the Holy One, Blessed be He: for usually everything in the chronicles is written not in the presence of the king, but this was written "before the king," as I will explain with Heaven's help.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 3

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther: Chapter 3

Section 1: Peshat (The Plain Interpretation)

(1) After these things — The explanation is: In the Gemara they said (Megillah 12b) that Memuchan is Haman, and his advice was to kill Vashti so that the King would have the power to judge matters concerning himself. For if he could not judge by himself, it would have been very difficult to execute judgment upon the great princes, those higher than the "five who see the king's face." However, his advice was effective in this regard. Therefore, the King promoted him greatly because he had done two great and good things for him. And regarding what they said (Megillah 13b) that "The Holy One, Blessed be He, creates the cure before the blow," this refers to that which is written later, "for so the king had commanded concerning him" (Esther 3:2). The Midrash states that "The King," when mentioned without qualification, refers to the Holy One, Blessed be He. If so, what does the word "After" relate to? Therefore, they said: After the Holy One, Blessed be He, created the cure for his [Israel's] blow.

Promoted [Haman] — The explanation is: with wealth, as it is said, "and the man went on becoming great" (Job 1:3).

And advanced him — In greatness.

The Agagite — This is mentioned to say that the fact that [Saul] spared Agag caused this [Haman's rise].

Above all the princes — The explanation is: For such is the way of all kings; when the princes sit, the king does not sit among them but by himself in a place higher than them. He did the same for Haman; therefore it is written "above all the princes," meaning higher than all of them.

(2) And all the king's servants — These are those who attend to him.

Who were in the king's gate — These are the attendants who sit at the king's gate.

The king had so commanded concerning him — The explanation is: The King told him [Haman] that he [the King] would command thus. This indicates great affection, as our Sages of blessed memory said: "Beloved are Israel… an extra measure of affection was made known to them" (Pirkei Avot 3:14).

But Mordechai would not bow down etc. — The explanation is: Haman made himself into an *avodah zarah* (idol), as it says in Tractate Sanhedrin (61b): "Can one be liable for an object that is worshipped like Haman?"

(3) Why do you transgress — The explanation is: In a matter from which you gain nothing.

(4) And they told Haman etc. — The explanation is: They told Haman to take notice of this sight, that he [Mordechai] does not bow, for Haman did not see this due to his great arrogance.

He had told them — The explanation is: The reason they told Haman was because he [Mordechai] said he was a Jew. As it is written, anyone who denies *avodah zarah* is called a "Jew." Therefore, his [Haman's] hatred toward him was very great, for there is no hatred like the hatred of religion; therefore he spoke.

(5) And Haman saw etc. bowing to him — The explanation is: Haman brought himself close to Mordechai so that Mordechai would see that he [Haman] was paying attention to this. For he thought perhaps Mordechai assumed Haman wasn't noticing. When he saw that even so he did not bow, "Haman was filled with wrath."

(6) But it was contemptible in his eyes — The explanation is: It was a disgrace to him to kill Mordechai alone, and also because of this fact that he did not bow to him.

The people of Mordechai — For they told him that he does not bow because he is a Jew.

And Haman sought etc. — The explanation is: To uproot the religion, as will be explained later.

All the Jews — For it was also contemptible in his eyes to lay a hand only on those in Shushan.

With Mordechai — And everything was because he is "with Mordechai," meaning the Jews, for whose sake Mordechai did not bow.

(7) He cast a Pur, that is, the lot — The explanation is: It says "Pur" to let us know that for this reason it is called "Purim," after the *Pur*. But since we do not know what a *Pur* is, it says "that is, the *Goral* (lot)." It is called Purim after the *Pur* because this is the essence of the miracle: that he cast a *Pur*—a lot according to the *mazalot* (zodiac signs/constellations)—to see on which day he could prevail over them, and it fell on the 13th of Adar. However, the Holy One, Blessed be He, overturned the *mazalot* and frustrated the celestial arrangements. This is the meaning of "the *Pur* was overturned into Purim," and this is a very great miracle.

Before Haman — The explanation is: It is known that Israel has no *mazal* (astrological fate) at all in the heavens, and all the *mazalot* are antagonistic toward Israel. This means that according to the *mazalot*, Abraham our Father, peace be upon him, was not fit to have a son, as he saw in his *astrologia* (astrology) that he was not fit to have a son. But the Holy One, Blessed be He, raised him above the *mazalot* and said to him, "So shall your offspring be" (Genesis 15:5), and gave to him from the *sitra de-dchura* (the male/dominant side) (Shabbat 156a). If so, according to the *mazalot*, Israel should not exist in the world at all. From where then would Israel have a *mazal*? Rather, they are included in a "General *Mazal*." (I have explained the matter of *mazal* in my commentary on Isaiah 5:30). This is the meaning of "you have begun to fall" (Esther 6:13), and our Sages said (Megillah 16a): "This nation is compared [to the stars and the dust]." This is because they have no *mazal* at all; rather, they are above the *mazalot*. That is, if they are righteous [they are above], and if not, they descend, Heaven forbid, to the dust. But if they are righteous, they rise to the heavens above the *mazalot*. Thus, he [Haman] could not cast lots to find when there

would be a bad *mazal* for Israel, for they have no *mazal* at all. Instead, he cast lots for when *his own* [Haman's] *mazal* would be strong—and this is specifically "before Haman."

From day to day and from month to month — The explanation is: First he cast lots on which day of the month he could prevail, and afterward on which month. For if he had cast on the month first, he would have had to cast on which day of the month for every single month. (The language here is distant and brief). "And it fell on the 13th of Adar"—meaning first it fell on the 13th of the month, and when he cast on the months, it fell on the month of Adar.

(8) There is a certain people — He did not mention them by name because he was afraid the King might say he does not want [to kill them] because he [the King] loves Mordechai; therefore he did not mention them.

Scattered and dispersed among the peoples — The explanation is: They themselves are scattered and not in one place, and they are also "dispersed among the peoples" in that they do not intermarry with the nations at all. They are separate from the nations, and there is no one who would incline to find merit for them.

In all the provinces of your kingdom — And they are all in your hand.

And their laws are different from every people — The explanation is: Therefore everyone hates them, and no one will pity them at all, nor will anyone have it in their heart to care about this.

And they do not keep the king's laws — A king benefits from a people in two ways: service to the king and taxes. But they "do not keep the king's laws," meaning the service of the king.

And it is not worth it for the king to tolerate them — For he has nothing from them at all.

(9) If it please the king — He said that it is not his own will, but only if it is the king's will; he is merely giving advice.

And ten thousand [talents of silver] etc. — On account of the tax that would have come to you from them, I am giving you ten thousand talents of silver.

I will weigh — The explanation is: The talent is of silver, therefore he said "I will weigh," that he would give it by weight.

Those who perform the work — Through those who mint coins.

(10) The adversary of the Jews — Since [Haman] had not mentioned which nation it was at all, [the verse] calls him "the adversary of the Jews."

(11) And the people, to do with them as it seems good in your eyes — The explanation is: Haman failed to mention two things: 1) He did not mention which nation. 2) He did not mention what to do with them, but simply said "to destroy them." This is why [the King] said "The people"—meaning whichever people you want; "to do with them as it seems good in your eyes"—whatever you wish.

(12) To the king's satraps — The explanation is: He wrote to the satraps that they should issue the decree to all the nations in the king's name, as the king writes.

Section 2: Remez (The Allegorical/Mystical Interpretation)

(13) To destroy, to kill, and to annihilate etc. and to plunder their possessions — The explanation is: There are four aspects to a person: *Nefesh* (vital soul), *Ruach* (spirit), *Neshamah* (higher soul), and *Guf* (body). The *Nefesh* and the *Guf* are one, as they said in the Zohar (II:142a) that the *Nefesh* is the partner of the body. The fourth aspect is *Kinyan* (possessions). It is known that the *Neshamah* is the primary element for its *mitzvot* (commandments). Haman wanted to uproot everything: 1. **To destroy** — These are the *mitzvot* which correspond to the *Neshamah*. 2. **To kill** — This is the spiritual *Ruach*. 3. **To annihilate** — Even the physical *Guf* from the world, so that no remnant of Israel remains. 4. **To plunder their possessions** — This is the *Kinyan*, that they should be for plunder and not remain in one place, so that their name does not remain in the world.

Correspondingly, we were given four things on the day of Purim: 1. **Reading the Megillah** — An additional *mitzvah* was added; this corresponds to his desire to annihilate the *Neshamah*. 2. **Simcha (Joy)** — Against the *Ruach* which is in the heart, as it says "My heart shall rejoice" (Proverbs 23:15); He gave us joy. 3. **Mishteh (Feasting)** — Against the *Guf*, so that the body should benefit from it. 4. **Matanot La'Evyonim (Gifts to the poor)** — Against "plunder their possessions," so that there should now be money even for the poor.

And as for what is said, that they should be killed on one day and afterward "their plunder for booty"—for if he had said they should also plunder [simultaneously], they might not [finish] killing on that day. Therefore he said they should not take plunder until they have killed, and also that the plunder should be theirs so that they would kill with more heart because of the money.

(14) The copy of the writing etc. revealed to all the peoples, to be ready for this day — The explanation is: He was afraid to write publicly that they should kill the Jews. For he knew that the Jews would pursue the high offices and people would incline to find merit for them. Yet he needed to write explicitly now so that they would know, for he had to send to all the ends of the earth so they would know to act against the Jews. Therefore he did this: he wrote to the satraps and governors "to destroy and to kill," but the "copy of the writing to be given as a decree" which would be "revealed to all the peoples" did not write [the details], but only that they should "be ready for this day"—meaning they should be prepared for this day, and on that day itself, they would be told [what to do].

(15) The couriers went out in haste by the king's command — The explanation is: He brought them before the King, and the King commanded them to go out in haste. The verse shows us here the greatness of the Holy One, Blessed be He, who did this so that there would be time [for the salvation] twice over.

And the decree was given in Shushan — The explanation is: In the first place, which is the seat of the kingdom.

And the city of Shushan was perplexed — For they saw that he wrote they should be ready for the 13th of Adar, but they did not know what it was.

Chapter 4 (Selected Commentary)

(1) And Mordechai knew all that had been done — [Remez]: He knew that they had bowed to the [image], and thus a decree of *Karet* (spiritual excision) was triggered Above.

(7) All that had happened to him — The explanation is: It happened because of the fact that he [Mordechai] did not bow.

(8) And to charge her — For he knew she was a great *Tzadeket* (righteous woman) and would not want to go of her own will to the wicked one [Ahasuerus]; therefore he had to command her.

(14) Relief and deliverance will arise for the Jews from another place — [Remez]: "Another place" refers to the Holy One, Blessed be He.

(16) And so I will go to the king, which is not according to the law — [Remez]: This refers to the "King of the World." "Not according to the law" means even without the proper spiritual preparation, because of the emergency.

Chapter 5 (Selected Commentary)

(1) Esther put on royalty — Our Sages said she was clothed in *Ruach HaKodesh* (Divine Inspiration). This is because *Ruach HaKodesh* does not rest upon a grieving body [and she had been fasting], therefore she had to be "clothed" in it now.

On his royal throne… opposite the entrance of the house — This shows the great providence of the Holy One, Blessed be He: He placed the King in the place of judgment [the throne] but made him look toward the entrance so he would see her immediately.

(2) And it was, when the king saw — The Gemara says three angels were appointed to her at that moment. This is derived from the word "When he saw" (*ki-rot*) rather than "After he saw." This implies it was not natural, but by a miracle. Thus it says "in his hand" to show that [the scepter] was small, yet it reached her; the angels performed three miracles.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 4

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther: Chapter 4

Plain Interpretation (Al Derech HaPeshat)

(1) All that had been done — and also that it was because of him [Mordechai] that he [Haman] did not kneel. **And he cried out a great and bitter cry** — "Great" over this great trouble, and also "bitter" to him, for it was because of him that all this came about.

(2) No one may enter — The explanation is: His desire was to enter the King's courtyard, but "no one may enter the King's gate" [in sackcloth].

(3) The King's word — This refers to the letter itself which he sent to the *achashdarpanim (satraps)*, the governors, and those ministers who had Jewish friends; therefore, they revealed it to them immediately. **And his decree** — This is the decree that was revealed to all the nations. **A great mourning for the Jews** — The explanation is: It was a mourning as if over a dead person, because they immediately saw the King's decree. **And fasting and weeping** — These are the five ways of *teshuvah (repentance)* explained in Tractate Ta'anit (15a). They said that "sackcloth and ashes" are only practiced by the leaders of the people, and this refers to the masses, and not to every single individual. **Spread out for the many** — This implies [it was done] by others, for so they said in the Gemara: "And they place [ashes] upon the head of the *Nasi (Prince/Leader)*."

(4) And to remove his sackcloth from him — The explanation is: That he should remove his sackcloth and come to her so she could speak with him [to ask] "what is this," for she thought he was afraid to speak through a messenger. **And he did not accept** — The explanation is: He did not want to separate from his sackcloth even for a single moment.

(5) And she commanded him concerning Mordechai — The explanation is: She commanded Hatach to go and speak with Mordechai; perhaps Hatach could elicit from his mouth "what this is." **To know**

what this is and why this is — The explanation is: One who wishes to know a matter clearly needs to know two things: 1) What is this thing? and 2) Why was this thing done? Regarding this, she asked "what this is" and "why this is."

(6) To the city square — To make known that he was not ashamed to cry out in the city square before the King's gate.

(7) All that had happened to him — The explanation is: That it came about through the fact that he did not kneel. **And the sum of money** — The explanation is: For he also told him to tell her this, because in the [public] decree it was not written that it referred to the Jews; therefore, he told her that the *patshegen (copy)* was against the Jews to destroy them.

(8) And the copy of the text… and to charge her — For he knew that she was a great *tzadeket (righteous woman)* and did not want to go to Achashverosh willingly; therefore, he "charged her." Once he charged her, she certainly would not violate the command of Mordechai. **To implore him and to request** — The explanation is: That she should say that for the sake of her *chen (grace/favor)* he should do this, as she said: "If I have found favor in your eyes…" (Esther 7:3), and that she should request of him intensely.

(11) All the king's servants — The explanation is: She said that she would not be effective, but on the contrary, she would cause harm, for it is well known that "any man or woman… there is but one law for him: to be put to death." In a matter that is well known, there will be a greater stumbling block if I violate his law. **Furthermore, "And I have not been called to come to the king…"** — And presumably, he will send for me in those [coming] days; why should I violate his law for the sake of a few days?

(13) And Mordechai said… "Do not imagine in your soul…" — The explanation is: Mordechai suspected that she thought one does not commit a sin so that one's fellow may gain merit [i.e., she shouldn't sacrifice her spiritual standing for the nation], and in this matter, it is a case of "be killed and do not transgress" [referring to her being with the King willingly], and she is not obligated in this. Therefore, he said that even without this, you will be killed; therefore, do not be lax, but go.

(14) You and your father's house will perish — The explanation is: As it says, "He who is slack in his work is a brother to a master of destruction" (Proverbs 18:9). The explanation is: If it is in one's hand to save and he does not save, not only does he not receive a reward, but he is like a murderer. Therefore, he said "you and your father's house will perish," and you—who are the Queen—all the more so.

(16) Who are found in Shushan — For [to gather] the whole world is impossible in such few days; therefore, she said "who are found in Shushan." **Which is not according to the law** — The explanation is: Willingly.

(17) And Mordechai passed — The explanation is: That he "passed" (transgressed) the law, for he sat in a fast on Pesach and did not eat *Matzah* and *Maror*. **According to all that Esther commanded him** — As it says in the Midrash (Esther Rabbah 8:7) that she said: "If there are no Jews, there is no Matzah and Maror." Furthermore, because she is the Queen, he is obligated to keep her command; and this is "according to all that Esther commanded him."

Allegorical Interpretation (Al Derech HaRemez)

[The GRA connects the struggle between Mordechai and Haman to the cosmic battle between the forces of holiness and the *Sitra Achra* (the Other Side/Evil)].

There are 18 [mentions of] "Haman" in the Torah, as is known (cf. *Sifrei* 17:8). In the future, they will hang him on a tree. For in the future it will be as it says, "And it shall be a time of trouble for Jacob, etc." (Jeremiah 30:7), for then the sin of *Adam HaRishon* (the First Man) will be rectified. And he [Haman/the Evil Inclination] will be punished for the exile to this place. And to him [the Evil Inclination], the King—who is the Holy One, Blessed be He—has died [meaning His presence is hidden], and Haman has conquered everything, *chas v'shalom (Heaven forbid)*.

Commentary on Chapter 5

(1) And she clothed herself — "Esther [clothed herself in] royalty." They said (Megillah 15a) that she clothed herself in *Ruach HaKodesh (Divine Inspiration)*. This is because *Ruach HaKodesh* does not rest upon a grieving body [and she had been fasting]. Therefore, she clothed herself in *Ruach HaKodesh* now. **On his royal throne** — To show the greatness of the love of the Holy One, Blessed be He: He [Achashverosh] sat in the place of judgment and made it a "house of royalty" [mercy], and he was not in his usual designated place, and he was also "facing the entrance of the house"—all so that he would see her immediately.

(2) And it was, when he saw — In the Gemara (Megillah 15b) they said: "Three angels were designated for her at that time, etc." This is derived from the word *kir'ot* (when he saw) rather than *ka'asher ra'ah* (as he saw). This implies it was not according to nature, but according to a miracle. Therefore, it is written *kir'ot*, which implies "automatically." Similarly, [the word] *nas'ah* (she carried/found favor) implies that it was carried [bestowed] upon her from above. Similarly, it says **"in his hand"**—this is seemingly redundant, for certainly it is in his hand. Rather, it is to show that it [the scepter] was small, yet it was [extended] from his hand. Therefore, three angels were designated for her at that time to perform three miracles.

(3) What is it for you… and what is your request — The explanation is: He saw that her face had changed due to the fast, as our Sages of blessed memory said (Megillah 15b) that she was unable to stand. Also, she had come into the inner [court] not according to the law and endangered her soul. Presumably, it was a very great matter. It must be one of three things: 1) Something she lacks, 2) Something she wants to request for the ministers. Therefore, he said "What is it for you," meaning what do you lack? "And what is your request," meaning on behalf of the ministers, "and it shall be given to you"—and it will be done according to your will.

(4) And Esther said, "If it please the King… to the banquet" — The explanation is: She said to him, "A very great matter is required of me, and I cannot tell you immediately, for perhaps Haman will [interfere]. But if you come to the banquet, and during the banquet when your heart is merry, then I will request."

(5) And the King said, "Hurry…" — The explanation is: He saw the greatness of her distress and said "Hurry," so that she would make her request and no longer be in distress. This is "to do the word of Esther," meaning that her request should be fulfilled.

(6) What is your petition… and what is your request — The explanation is: "Petition" (*she'elah*) and "request" (*bakashah*) are two different things. A petition is for oneself, and a request is for others. Therefore, he said: "What is your petition" for yourself, "and what is your request" for others? Regarding your petition, he said "it shall be given to you," meaning what you lack; and regarding your request for others, he said "it shall be done"—when I do this with him [Haman], whatever you request.

(8) If I have found favor… and if it please the King — The explanation is: If I have favor, that is a sign for my petition [for myself]; and if it is good in the eyes of the King, [that is for] my request for others. "Let the King and Haman come…" for even now I cannot speak yet because of the greatness of my distress. Her intention was as stated in the Gemara (Megillah 15b). Also, she did not want to request of him [yet] because perhaps he [Achashverosh] would know the matter was [unfavorable] in the eyes of the Holy One, Blessed be He, and it would not help at all. Therefore, she pushed it off until tomorrow, for perhaps by tomorrow the matter would be known from Heaven that they agree with her. Therefore, she said "tomorrow I will do as the King says" and I will tell you. **To the banquet that I shall make for them** — She said this so that Haman would think he was very important in her eyes, just as in the eyes of the King. Therefore, she said "I will make for *them*," but regarding the first banquet she said only "I made for *him* [the King]."

(9) Joyful and glad of heart — The explanation is: "Joyful" in his soul [eternal joy] and "glad of heart" that he had no fear at all. For until now, he was afraid that perhaps she was thinking against him, since she grew up in his [Mordechai's] house. But now he saw that she brought him close along with the King, and she did not bring Mordechai close; he thought she favored him more than Mordechai. Therefore, it is written now: "And Haman was filled with wrath against Mordechai." For now, what was his [Mordechai's] security? Even Es-

ther does not favor him. **He did not rise and did not stir before him** — The explanation is: He did not tremble before him at all. For those who are afraid of him stand before him until he passes, but Mordechai did not stir from his place as he was.

(11) And Haman recounted to them… — The explanation is: When a person is in great joy and great pleasures, and afterward he sees distress, even a small [distress] can cause him to die. To prevent this, he must ease the distress from his heart by seeing honor and pleasures. Therefore, Haman, since he was "joyful and glad of heart" and afterward saw that Mordechai did not kneel to him, had great distress and could have died from this distress. Therefore, he recounted to them "the glory of his wealth." **He promoted him** — In money. **He raised him** — In honor, as it says regarding the *patshegen* (decree) that he made for them.

(14) Let a gallows be made, fifty cubits high… — He said they should hang him on a high tree so that he would see him immediately. If he were just killed, he wouldn't see him afterward, but if they hang him, he will see him always. They said they should make it fifty cubits high because seeing is greater than hearing in four ways, and one of them is that the sight of a thing is greater than the hearing of a thing. Therefore, Haman, when he would be in the King's house, would not see that they hung Mordechai [if it were low]; therefore, he made it fifty cubits high so that he could see from a distance from where the King was. This advice was from the Holy One, Blessed be He, so that Achashverosh could see for himself, for "hearing is not like seeing," as it says: "Behold also the tree, etc." (Esther 7:9). **And in the morning, speak to the King** — The explanation is: Go in the morning, and not in his usual way of going to the King as one who lacks [something]. For the second-to-the-king is usually the last to enter, but go in the morning before anyone else is with the King, so that you will be the first with the King and you will be the one to [decide] the fate of Mordechai and anticipate his [Mordechai's] request to the King. Therefore, they said "go in the morning." **And he made the gallows** — He himself made the tree from the cedar of his house.

Commentary on Chapter 6

(1) On that night, the King's sleep was disturbed — For he saw in a dream that she [Esther] endangered her soul and requested of the King, and Haman [was there]. Regarding the banquet, from the joy he had distress. Certainly, she is not endangering herself to request for herself, for what does she lack in the King's house? The joy [she seeks] must be to request for someone else. And who is this? He said: Since she has no family or nation at all, it must be for Mordechai who raised her in his house. And she also invited Haman, for perhaps he is also a friend to Mordechai and they are planning together to take revenge on me. And he said in his heart: "Who knows what she will request? For certainly it is no small thing since she endangered her soul for it." He also said in his heart: "Certainly they will say and claim that he [Mordechai] did a favor for the King, for without a favor one cannot request." Therefore, he wanted to bring "the book of records, the chronicles," to see what favor Mordechai did, so that he could respond that this is not such a great favor as to do such a very great thing for him. **The book of records, the chronicles** — The explanation is: Not the chronicles themselves, for the chronicles are large, as they contain in writing everything done since the creation of the world. Rather, "the book of records," for they had a book in brief of every matter of the ministers, and he wanted to bring that.

(3) And the King said… — For he said in his heart: "Now she is requesting for him intensely, for he also has a great claim." And he asked if "honor and greatness" had been done for this, so that he could respond that honor and greatness had already been done. "Honor" in respect, and "greatness" in money.

(4) Who is in the court? — The explanation is: To take counsel with him what to do before she makes her request. For who knows what she will request? And also, the law is with her, as she has a great claim. **Which he had prepared for him** — Behold, in the Gemara (Megillah 16a) they said: "He [Haman] prepared it for himself." This is not [explicitly] prepared [in the text]. It appears the explanation is: Since I have already written that the decree was from Heaven [originally] against Mordechai, and afterward it was overturned and the decree was against Haman—therefore, "he prepared it for him," meaning the

decree was also from Heaven against Haman alone and not against Mordechai.

(5) And the King said, "Let him enter" — For he thought he [Haman] stood in the morning to request concerning Mordechai. And he said in his heart: "Who knows what Esther's will is to request on behalf of Mordechai? For Haman is also in that same [category of] punishment."

(6) What should be done for the man… — And he did not say "for Mordechai," for he was afraid that if he said "for Mordechai," he [Haman] would say to give him the entire kingdom, for he [the King] thought that he [Haman] was also a friend to Mordechai. Therefore, he spoke generally. **Whom the King desires to honor** — And he did not say "greatness" as he said before [to the servants]. For this was from Heaven, that he should only say "honor." For if he had said "greatness," he [Haman] could not have applied it to himself, for what "greatness" could be given to him further? For he had already given Haman much, and he was already second to the King. But "honor" was possible, as explained later.

(7) The man whom the King desires to honor — But "greatness," it is impossible to give him more.

(8) Let them bring royal apparel… — The explanation is: For he lacked nothing but this. **And upon whose head a royal crown has been set** — The explanation is: That apparel and that horse upon which the King rode on the day that a royal crown was set upon his head.

(9) And let the apparel and the horse be delivered… — The explanation is: That it should be in the days when they prepare the horse for the King to ride, and the time of the *partemim (nobles)* to prepare the horse for the transition [of the King]. And Haman said that they should do this for him too. **And let them clothe the man** — The explanation is: His servants [should clothe him], and not he himself. And similarly "and they shall lead him on horseback" and "and they shall proclaim before him."

(10) Hurry, take… — The explanation is: He [the King] saw that he [Haman] said this regarding Mordechai… [text ends].

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 5

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther

Chapter 5

(1) And Esther clothed herself in royalty etc. – And [the Sages] said (Megillah 15a) that she clothed herself in *Ruach HaKodesh* (Divine Inspiration). This is because *Ruach HaKodesh* only rests upon a "drunken body" [meaning a body nullified to the physical, or in a state of spiritual ecstasy], and therefore she clothed herself in *Ruach HaKodesh* now. **On his royal throne etc.** – To show the greatness of the Holy One, Blessed be He's causation: for the throne is the place of judgment, and now it was in the "royal house" [the throne room] and not in his private inner chamber where he was always accustomed to be. Furthermore, it was opposite the entrance of the house, all so that he would see her immediately.

(2) And it was, when he saw etc. – In the Gemara (Megillah 15b) they said that three angels were provided for her at that moment. This is derived from the fact that it is written *ke-rot* (as the seeing of) and not *ka-asher ra'ah* (when he saw). This perforce implies that it was not according to nature, but rather by way of a miracle. Therefore, it wrote *ke-rot*, which implies it happened "of itself" [spontaneously]. Similarly, "she won [favor]" (*nas'ah*) implies she was "carried" by that which was placed upon her [divine grace]. Likewise, it says "in his hand" (*be-yado*); this is seemingly redundant, for certainly it was in his hand! Rather, it is to teach that [the scepter] was small and only in his hand [at first], and therefore the three angels were provided for her at that moment to perform three miracles [stretching the scepter, etc.].

(3) What is it to you… and what is your request – The explanation is: He saw that her face had changed because of the fast, as our Sages of blessed memory said (Megillah 15a) that she could not even hold

up her head. Furthermore, she went to the inner court "not according to the law" (Esther 4:16) and risked her life. Presumably, it was a very great matter, and it must be one of two things: 1) Perhaps there is someone who is distressing her. 2) Perhaps she wants to request on behalf of others. Therefore, he said, **"What is it to you"** — meaning, what do you lack personally? **"And what is your request"** — meaning, on behalf of others. **"And it shall be given to you"** — and I will do according to your will.

(4) And Esther said, if it please the king… to the banquet – The explanation is: She said to him that a very great thing is required by me, and I cannot tell you immediately, for perhaps you will not grant it to me. However, if you come to the banquet, and during the banquet when your heart is merry, then I will request.

(5) And the king said, hurry etc. – The explanation is: He saw the greatness of her distress and said "Hurry etc." so that she might make her request and no longer be in distress. This is the meaning of **"to do the word of Esther,"** namely, that her request should be fulfilled.

(6) What is your petition… and what is your request – The explanation is: For "petition" (*she'elah*) and "request" (*bakashah*) are two different things. A petition is for oneself, and a request is for others. Therefore, he said: "What is your petition" for yourself, "and what is your request" for others? Regarding your petition, he said **"it shall be given to you"** — meaning that which you lack; and regarding your request for others, he said **"it shall be done"** (*te'aseh*) — that I will do this with him [the third party] whatever you request.

(7) And she said, my petition and my request – The explanation is: I will request two things: one for myself and one for others.

(8) If I have found favor… and if it please the king – The explanation is: I have "favor" (*chen*) that he should grant my petition [for myself], and "if it is good in the eyes of the king" regarding my request for others, **"let the king and Haman come etc."** For even now I cannot say more because of the greatness of my distress. Her intention was as stated in the Gemara (Megillah 15b) [to make the king jealous of Haman], and also that she did not want to request from him yet, for perhaps the matter would be evil in the eyes of the Holy One, Blessed be He, and it would not help at all. Therefore, she pushed it off until

tomorrow, for perhaps she would know of something from which it would be known that Heaven also agreed, as indeed happened. Therefore, she said that tomorrow "I will do according to your word" and tell you. **To the banquet that I shall prepare for them** – She said this so that Haman would think he was very important in her eyes, just as he was in the eyes of the king. Therefore, she said "I will prepare *for them*," whereas at first she only said "I have prepared *for him*."

(9) Joyful and glad of heart – The explanation is: "Joyful" (*samayach*) refers to [internal joy], and "glad of heart" (*tov lev*) means he had no fear at all. For until now he was afraid that perhaps she loved Mordechai, since she grew up in his house. But now that he saw she invited him with the king, and did not invite Mordechai, presumably she loves him more than Mordechai. Therefore, it is written now: **"Haman was filled with wrath against Mordechai,"** for now, upon what was his [Mordechai's] security? For even Esther does not love him. **And he did not rise or stir before him – The explanation is:** He did not even tremble before him at all. For a person whom one fears, people stand before him until he passes, but Mordechai did not even stir from him, as if he [Haman] did not exist.

(11) And Haman recounted to them etc. – The explanation is: When a person is in great joy and great pleasures, and afterward sees distress—even a small amount—he can die from it. The remedy is to vent the distress from his heart and to see honor and increase in pleasures. Therefore, Haman, who was joyful and glad of heart, and afterward saw that Mordechai did not bow to him, had great distress from this and could have died from that distress. Therefore, he recounted to them the glory of his wealth. **His greatness** – in money. **He promoted him** – in honor, as explained above on the verse "which I shall prepare for them."

(14) Let them make a gallows fifty cubits high etc. – Therefore, she [Zeresh] said they should hang him on a high tree, because with other forms of death, one does not see him afterward, but if they hang him, he will see him always. And they said to make it fifty cubits high because sight is greater than hearing in four ways, and one of them is that the sight of a thing is greater than the hearing of a thing. Therefore, when Haman would be in the king's house, he would not

see him when they hanged Mordechai [if it were low]; therefore, he made it fifty cubits high so that he could see it from a distance from the king's court. This was a cause brought about by the Holy One, Blessed be He, so that Ahasuerus would be able to see it himself, for "hearing is not like seeing," as it says: "Behold also the gallows etc." (Esther 7:9). **And in the morning, speak to the king etc. – The explanation is:** That he should go in the morning and not according to his usual way of going to the king late, for the second-in-command to the king usually goes last. However, [they said] you should go in the morning before anyone else is with the king, for perhaps someone will be with the king who is a friend of Mordechai and will intercede for him to the king. Therefore, they said he should go in the morning. **And he made the gallows** – He himself made the gallows, for "hatred upsets the natural order" (Bereishis Rabbah 55:8).

Chapter 6

Peshat (Plain Meaning)

(1) On that night, the king's sleep was disturbed. For he saw in a dream [Esther] risking her life and requesting of the king and Haman, and because of the banquet she has distress. Certainly, she is not risking her life to request for herself, for what does she lack in the king's house? Rather, she must want to request for someone else. And who is this? Since she has no family or people at all, it must be for Mordechai who raised her in his house. And she also invited Haman, for perhaps he is also a friend to Mordechai and they both want to request together. Ahasuerus thought in his heart: "Who knows what Esther wants to request for Mordechai? For surely it is no small thing since she risked her life for it." He also said in his heart: "Surely they will say and claim that he did a favor for the king, for without a favor one does not request." Therefore, he wanted to bring the "book of records, the chronicles" to see what favor Mordechai had done, so that he could argue that this favor is not so great as to do such a very great thing for him. And it says **"the book of records, the chronicles"** — mean-

ing, not the chronicles themselves, for the chronicles are large, as they contain in writing everything that happened since the creation of the world. Rather, it was the "book of records," for they had a book that was a summary of all the main events, and he wanted to bring that.

(3) And the king said etc. – For he said in his heart: "Now she is requesting for him very much, for he also has a great claim." And he asked if "honor and greatness" had been done for this, so that he could argue that honor and greatness had already been done. "Honor" (*yekar*) in respect, and "greatness" (*gedulah*) in money.

(4) Who is in the court? – The explanation is: To take counsel with him what to do before she makes her request, for who knows what she will request? And also, the law is with her, for she has a great claim. **Which he had prepared for him.** – Behold, in the Gemara (Megillah 16a) they said: "He prepared for himself." This is difficult to understand. It appears the explanation is based on what I have already written: that the decree was from Heaven, originally against Mordechai, and afterward it was overturned and the hatred was directed at Haman. Therefore, "he prepared for himself" means the hatred was also from Heaven against Haman alone and not against Mordechai.

(5) And the king said: Let him enter. For he thought that he [Haman] stood there in the morning to request for Mordechai, for he thought in his heart: "Who knows what Esther's will is to request for Mordechai? For Haman was also at that banquet."

(6) What shall be done for the man. He did not say "for Mordechai," for he was afraid that if he said "for Mordechai," Haman would say to give him the entire kingdom, for he [the king] thought that Haman was also a friend to Mordechai. Therefore, he spoke generally. **Whom the king desires to honor.** He did not say "greatness" (*gedulah*) as he said before, for this was from Heaven—that he should not say "greatness," for then Haman would have been able to claim it for himself. For what "greatness" could he give him further? For he had already given Haman much, and he was already second to the king. But "honor" is possible, as explained later.

(7) The man whom the king desires to honor. But "greatness" is impossible to give him more.

(8) Let them bring royal apparel etc. – The explanation is: For he lacked nothing but this. **And upon whose head a royal crown is set. – The explanation is:** That apparel and that horse upon which the king rode on the day the royal crown was placed on his head.

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Meaning)

(9) And let the apparel… be delivered etc. – The explanation is: For in those days, there were those who would prepare the horse for the king to ride, and there was a time for the nobles to prepare the horse to be passed over [to the rider]. Haman said that they should do this for him as well. **And they shall dress the man. – The explanation is:** His servants, and not a noble. Similarly, "and they shall lead him on horseback" and "and they shall proclaim before him." [Haman's ego led him to suggest that the highest nobles serve the recipient, but here the GRA notes Haman's assumption that he would be the recipient].

(10) Hurry, take. – The explanation is: For he saw that he [Haman] said this for Mordechai, and he thought that Haman prepared this because he was for Mordechai and said so because of his love for him. From here Ahasuerus understood that this was possible. And he said to him: "Do with him even better than what you said, and do not omit anything." And from all this, do it quickly, for immediately you will be called with Esther to the banquet, and you will be able to argue that "I have already done for him." **Do not omit a word etc. – The explanation is:** All that you spoke, even what you said "my servants shall do," you do it yourself, and do not omit anything.

(11) And he dressed Mordechai. They said in the Gemara (Megillah 16a): "He went and found the Rabbis [learning]." But it is difficult, for how could he find them? [The GRA discusses the logistics of Haman finding the Sages and Mordechai in the study hall during the decree].

Chapter 7

Peshat (Plain Meaning)

(12) And he was pushed. – The explanation is: He ran quickly, for he was ashamed to stand there, and he ran. **Mourning and with his head covered.** – For he was ashamed of the matter, like one who is a mourner for the king; such a person would be covered and in mourning.

(13) And Haman recounted etc. all that had befallen him. – The explanation is: For they thought that since he came to the king to ask to hang Mordechai, and instead the king called for Mordechai and honored him, the king must have seen that the law was with Mordechai. Therefore, he wanted Haman to lead Mordechai on the horse for this reason. And afterward, it is possible that now Mordechai will be the second to the king and not Haman. Haman recounted to them "all that had befallen him" — meaning that it was a "happenstance" (*mikreh*) and he did not know from where all this came to him. To this they replied: **"If Mordechai be of the seed of the Jews." The explanation is:** Since it is a happenstance, it is from Heaven, for "Israel has no *mazal* (constellation/fate)" (Shabbat 156a). Therefore, you will not be able to prevail against him. For they [Israel] can overturn all the constellations, for they rise above to the heavens. Therefore, they are called "Hebrews" (*Ivrim*), for they transcend (*ovrim*) the constellations.

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Meaning)

Since "Israel has no *mazal*," they said he should prepare the gallows and he would be caught in what he prepared for his own downfall, and he [Mordechai] would make peace with him. But he [Haman] said this is a happenstance, and perhaps he could still overcome him.

(14) While they were yet talking with him. For it was possible that he would change the gallows he had made. Therefore, the "word of the Holy One, Blessed be He" hurried, and the king's chamberlains arrived.

7: (1) To drink with Esther the queen. For at the first banquet, Esther did not drink, for she was in mourning. But now she drank, as it says "with Esther the queen."

(2) What is your petition… and what is your request. – The explanation is: What is your petition for yourself, and what is your request for others, and it shall be done.

(3) If I have found favor in your eyes, O king, and if it please the king. – The explanation is: For two things are necessary: 1) That it be the will of the king, and 2) That she find favor in his eyes to grant it to her. Therefore: "If I have found favor" [personally], "and if it please the king" [the request itself]. **My life in my petition, and my people in my request. – The explanation is:** My petition for myself is that he give me my life. And my request for others is for my people.

(4) For we are sold, I and my people. She said "we are sold" because they were delivered [to Haman].

Chapter 7 (Continued)

Peshat (Right Column)

Ahasuerus gave Israel into Haman's hand by way of a sale, as it says "The silver is given to you" (Esther 3:11) — meaning as a gift. He did not say "it is forgiven to you," for if he gave the silver as a gift, [it implies a transaction]. And she said: **"But if we had been sold for bondmen etc."** She said two things corresponding to "If I have found favor" and "If it please the king." "If I have found favor" — you should see my affliction, for "we are sold, I and my people." And "if it please the king" — it should be according to the king's intent, **"for the adversary is not worth the king's damage." The explanation is:** That which causes damage to the king.

(5) Who is he, and where is he etc. – The explanation is: "Who is he" who presumed in his heart to take the queen? "And where is he" — this refers to your people. For it was difficult for him [to believe] since she said she did not know her own people. "Who is he" is like "Who is he that is pure of heart" and "Where are the hands that did this?"

(6) And Esther said etc. – In the Gemara (Megillah 16a) they said: She was pointing toward Ahasuerus, and an angel came and pushed

her hand toward Haman. Behold, this is a great wonder: why would she point toward Ahasuerus? It appears the reason is because the Sages said that the power of imagination creates an impression on a person. Just as we see one who wants to call "Simeon" but calls "Reuben" because in his thoughts it was Reuben. Know that it is the way of all the righteous that when they speak words before a king, their heart and thoughts are cleaved to the Holy One, Blessed be He, as it says "My Master, the dream is for your foes etc." (Daniel 4:16). Similarly, in Nehemiah (2:4): "For what do you request? And I prayed etc." So too here, her blessing was to the Holy One, Blessed be He, and he was in her thoughts.

Remez (Left Column)

[Regarding her pointing] at Ahasuerus: her thought and imagination were the reason. And she pointed her hand toward Ahasuerus [meaning the King of Kings], but an angel came and pushed her hand toward Haman. **And Haman was terrified before the king and the queen.** For previously, he could have said that he did not know they were her family. And before the king, he could have said the truth—that they are a people, but they are evil, as he said [previously]. But before both of them, he had no excuse at all. For how could he say before the queen that they are evil? And how could he say to the king that he did not know they were her people, when he had said they were evil? This would be a total contradiction.

(7) To the palace garden. In the Gemara (Megillah 16a) they said: He saw ministering angels who appeared to him as men [uprooting the trees]. This is because since Haman plotted against Israel with words of falsehood and lies, so the Holy One, Blessed be He, did with him as He did to Pharaoh, as it says "And they saw the Egyptians etc." and so too with Laban. As it says "For the Lord is upright etc. and there is no injustice in Him" (Psalm 92:16). **The explanation is:** That the Holy One, Blessed be He, is upright, and what a person sees sometimes as "injustice" — such as here, or in Egypt, or with Laban — "there is no injustice in Him." It is not a great injustice, but rather they did [evil] and they are deserving of this, for the Holy One, Blessed be He, pays them measure for measure. **And Haman stood. – The**

explanation is: When the king went out, he stood to request for his life, as mentioned above.

(8) And Haman was falling. – The explanation is: According to its plain meaning, because of the greatness of the distress, he was unable to stand and he fell. **Will he even force the queen with me in the house? – The explanation is:** According to his thought that he [Haman] wants to kill the queen and her people. Now that he is falling, [the king interprets it] as if he wants to kill her in his own house. **The word went out of the king's mouth, and they covered Haman's face. – The explanation is:** He was ashamed of this, for he could not answer him. For he was requesting for his life—what could he request? For he was the one who had said [the Jews] should be destroyed, as mentioned above.

(9) One of the chamberlains. In the Gemara (Megillah 16a) they said: He [Harbonah] was also in that plot [originally]. **The explanation is:** For he was one of the king's chamberlains who always stand before him, and he knew Haman. But perforce, he was in that plot [and now turned against him].

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 6

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther

Chapter 6

(1) On that night the King's sleep was disturbed — For he saw that Esther had risked her life and requested the King and Haman to the feast; presumably, she is in distress. Certainly, she does not need to request anything for herself, for what does she lack in the king's house? Presumably, she wishes to request on behalf of another. And who is this other, seeing as she has no family or nation at all? It must be for Mordechai, who raised her in his home. And she invited Haman as well, for perhaps he also loves Mordechai, and it is the will of both of them together to request on his behalf.

He thought in his heart: Who knows what she will request? For it is surely no small matter, since she risked her life for it. However, he said in his heart: Surely they will claim and argue that he [Mordechai] did a favor for the king, for without a favor one does not make requests. Therefore, he commanded to bring the *Sefer HaZichronos Divrei HaYamim* (Book of Records, the Chronicles) to see what favor Mordechai had done, so that he could respond that it was not such a great favor as to warrant doing a very great thing for him.

And he said the Book of Records, the Chronicles — *Peirush* (The explanation is): Not the Chronicles itself, for the Chronicles is large, as everything done since the creation of the world is written there. Rather, the "Book of Records," for they had a book that summarized every matter briefly, and he commanded to bring that.

(3) And the king said — For he said in his heart: Now she is requesting for him intensely because he also has a great claim. He asked if "honor and greatness" had been done for Mordechai for this, so that they could answer: "Honor and greatness have already been done." *Yekar* (Honor) refers to respect, and *Gedulah* (Greatness) refers to money.

(4) Who is in the courtyard? — *Peirush*: To take counsel with him on what to do before the feast, for who knows what she will request? And justice is also with her, as she has a great claim.

Which he had prepared for him — Behold, in the Gemara they said: "A Tanna taught: He prepared it for himself" (Megillah 16a). This is not understood. It appears that the explanation is as follows: Because I would have said that the decree was originally from Heaven against Mordechai and afterwards it was overturned and became Haman's; therefore, the Tanna taught "He prepared it for himself," meaning that from the beginning it was also decreed from Heaven against Haman alone and not against Mordechai.

(5) And the king said: Let him enter — For he thought that he [Haman] stood in the morning to request for Mordechai, and he said in his heart: Who knows what Esther's desire is to request for Mordechai, for Haman was also in that same counsel.

(6) What shall be done for the man — And he did not say "for Mordechai," because he was afraid that if he said "for Mordechai,"

Haman would say to give him the entire kingdom, for he thought that Haman also loved Mordechai; therefore, he spoke generally.

Whom the king desires to honor — And he did not say "greatness" as at the beginning. For this was from Heaven: that if he had said "greatness" as well, Haman would not have been able to answer this for himself, for what "greatness" could he give him further? For he had already given Haman much of his own, and he was also the second to the king. But "honor" is possible, as it says later.

(7) The man whom the king desires to honor — But "greatness" is impossible to give him any more.

(8) Let them bring royal apparel, etc. — *Peirush*: For he lacked nothing but this.

And upon which the royal crown was set on its head — *Peirush*: That apparel and the horse which the king rode upon on the day the royal crown was placed on his head.

(9) And let the apparel be delivered, etc. — *Peirush*: For it was the custom among them that when they would harness the horse for the king to ride, the chief of the nobles would give the horse to the servant who harnesses the horse. Haman said that they should do this for him as well.

And let them dress the man — *Peirush*: His servants, and not the noble. And likewise "and let them lead him" and "and let them proclaim."

(10) Hurry, take — *Peirush*: For he [Achashverosh] saw that he [Haman] spoke thus for Mordechai. He thought that Haman understood it was for Mordechai and said so because of his love for him. Achashverosh thought: It is good that I should be exempt with this, and he said to him: "Do even better with him—that you yourself shall do this, and only then will I be exempt with this." And "Hurry, do it," for Esther will immediately call to the feast, and I will be able to answer that I have already done for him.

Do not let a word fall, etc. — *Peirush*: Everything that you spoke, even what you said my servants should do, you shall do it all yourself. And this is "do not let [yourself] fall."

(11) And he dressed Mordechai — They said in the Gemara: "Esther forbade all the bath-attendants and barbers in Shushan" (Megillah

16a). The Gemara is not understood at all, for how is it possible that she could command all the bath-attendants and barbers in Shushan? Furthermore, she had shown herself to love him [Haman], and Haman also had many sons and servants. Rather, it appears the explanation is: Esther "bound" them with a [Divine] Name, as they said in the Gemara: "I bound the boat with a Name" (Shabbat 81b), meaning they were physically unable to do it.

(12) Hurried (Pushing himself) — *Peirush*: He ran quickly because he was ashamed to stand there, so he was running.

Mourning and with his head covered — For he was ashamed that a person of his stature, second to the king, should be a barber and a bath-attendant.

(13) And Haman told… all that had happened to him — *Peirush*: For they thought that since he came to the king and said to hang Mordechai, and the king sent and called Mordechai, and Mordechai answered, and the king saw that justice was with Mordechai—therefore he commanded that because of this, Haman should lead Mordechai. If so, it is possible that now Mordechai will be second to the king and not Haman. But Haman told them "all that had happened to him," meaning that it was a *mikreh* (coincidence/happenstance) and he did not know from where all this came to him. To this they replied: "If Mordechai be of the seed of the Jews." *Peirush*: Since it is a coincidence, it is from Heaven, for "there is no *mazal* (constellation/fate) for Israel" (Shabbat 156a). Therefore, you will not prevail over him, for they are able to overturn all the constellations, for when they rise, they rise up to the firmament. Therefore they were called "wise men," for they understood the constellations and understood that there is no *mazal* for Israel. They told him to hide the gallows and break what he had prepared to do and make peace with him. But he [Haman] said: "This is a coincidence," and perhaps he could hang him afterwards.

(14) While they were yet talking with him — For it was possible that he would break the gallows he had made; therefore, it was a cause from the Blessed Hashem that the king's chamberlains arrived.

Chapter 7

(1) To drink with Esther the Queen — For at the first feast, she was not called "Esther the Queen" because she was in a state of mourning, but now she was called "Esther the Queen."

(2) What is your petition… and what is your request — *Peirush*: What is your petition for yourself, and what is your request for others, and it shall be done.

(3) If I have found favor in your eyes, O King, and if it please the King — *Peirush*: For two things are necessary: 1) That it be the King's will, and 2) That she find favor in his eyes to grant it. Therefore: "If I have found favor" [refers to the favor], and "If it please the King" refers to the King's will.

My life at my petition, and my people at my request — *Peirush*: My petition for myself is that he give me my life; my request for others is for my people.

(4) For we are sold, I and my people — She said "sold" because he [Achashverosh] had handed them over.

[Peshat continued] — Achashverosh gave Israel into Haman's hand as a sale, as it says: "The money is given to you" (Esther 3:11), *Peirush*: as a gift. He did not say "it is forgiven to you," for if he gave the money as a gift, [it implies a transaction]. She said: "But if we had been sold for bondmen and bondwomen, I would have held my peace." She said two things corresponding to "If I have found favor" and "If it please the King." *Peirush*: If I have found favor, you will see my affliction, for "we are sold, I and my people." And "if it please the King," for "the adversary is not worthy of the King's damage," *Peirush*: that which causes damage to the King.

(5) Who is he, and where is he… — *Peirush*: Who is he whose heart has filled him to take the Queen? And "where is he" refers to your people, for it was difficult for him that she said she did not know her people. "Who is he" is like "Who is he that is pure of heart" [Job 17:3] and "where are the hands…"

(6) And Esther said… — In the Gemara they said: "She was pointing toward Achashverosh, but an angel came and pushed her hand toward Haman" (Megillah 16a). Behold, this is a great wonder—why would she point toward Achashverosh? It appears that because the

Sages said that the power of imagination makes an impression on a person—as we see one who wants to call 'Shimon' but calls 'Reuven' because in his thought it was Reuven. Know that it is the way of all the *Tzaddikim* (righteous) that when they speak words before a king, their heart and thought are cleaved to the Holy One, Blessed be He, as it says: "My Master, your dream is for your enemies, etc." (Daniel 4:16). And so too in Nehemiah 2:4: "For what do you make request? So I prayed, etc." So too here, her blessing was to the Holy One, Blessed be He, and in her thought [she was addressing God].

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Interpretation)

[On Verse 6] — Regarding Achashverosh and the thought of imagination, that is the reason she pointed toward Achashverosh, and an angel came and pushed her hand toward Haman.

Haman was terrified before the King and the Queen — For previously he could have said he did not know they were her family. Before the King, he could have said the truth—that they are a nation, but they are evil, as it says [in his earlier argument]. But before both of them, he had no excuse at all. For how could he say before the Queen that they are evil? And how could he say to the King that he did not know they were her people, for then he would have to say they are evil, and that would be even more of a rebellion [against her].

(7) Into the palace garden — In the Gemara they said: "He saw ministering angels who appeared to him as men [uprooting the trees]" (Megillah 16a). This is because since Haman plotted against Israel with words of falsehood and lies, so the Holy One, Blessed be He, did with him as He did to Pharaoh, as it says: "And they saw the Egyptians, etc." and so too with Laban. As it says: "For the ways of Hashem are right, etc. and the transgressors shall stumble therein" (Hosea 14:10). *Peirush*: The Holy One, Blessed be He, is upright, and what a person sees sometimes as injustice—like here, and in Egypt, and with Laban—it is not injustice at all, but rather they acted [wickedly] and are worthy of this, that the Holy One, Blessed be He, pays them back *middah keneged middah* (measure for measure).

And Haman stood up — *Peirush*: When the King left, he stood to beg for his life, as mentioned above.

(8) And Haman was falling — *Peirush*: According to the *Peshat* (plain meaning), it was because of the greatness of the terror; he was unable to stand and fell.

Will he even force the Queen before me in the house? — *Peirush*: According to the thought that he wants to kill the Queen and her people, now he is "falling" [attacking] from the thought that he wants to kill her in his house.

The word went out of the King's mouth, and they covered Haman's face — *Peirush*: He was in such shame that he could not answer him, for he was begging for his life. For what could he request? He was like one who is already dead.

(9) One of the chamberlains — In the Gemara they said: "He [Charvonah] was also in that [Haman's] counsel" (Megillah 16a). *Peirush*: For he was one of the king's chamberlains who stand before him always, and Haman knew this; therefore, he must have been in that counsel. *Peirush*: Meaning, that Haman sent him to bring him [Haman] to the feast. And therefore he knew [about the gallows].

Behold also the gallows — *Peirush*: This is the gallows that he showed him, as mentioned above.

Who spoke good for the King — This was a measure from Hashem, that he should speak in this language, to break the [evil] line, for Haman had spoken [against the one who spoke] good, so this [gallows] should be for the one who spoke good for the King.

(10) And the King's wrath was stilled — And they said: "[The wrath of the] King of the world" (Megillah 16a), and this is because the "King" mentioned here is the Holy One, Blessed be He.

Chapter 8

(1) On that day — For they are "good days," like the "other days," as it says: "And it was in the days of, etc." and therefore it is written here "on that day." But until now, when it was still a time of distress, it is written "And it was in the days." "In those days" [implies] that the "He" [God] was in concealment.

The King gave, etc. — As it says: "For to the man who is good before Him, He gives wisdom and knowledge and joy; but to the sinner He gives the task of gathering and amassing, to give to him who is good before God" (Ecclesiastes 2:26). They said in the Gemara: This refers to Mordechai, as it says: "And seeking good for his people" (Esther 10:3). And this is the meaning of "to him who is good before God," for this was Achashverosh's will, which is called "good before Him" [before God].

"He gave wisdom" — to Mordechai, who was the head of all the wise men, and it is written: "And a man of understanding from all the heavens." And Haman was "wisdom" [in a negative sense], as the Sages said: "A wise man to do evil is Haman." Therefore, he was taken from him and given to the "sinner" [to be gathered].

"And knowledge" — as it says: "And Mordechai knew all that was done," meaning through *Ruach HaKodesh* (Divine Inspiration).

"And joy" — as it says: "And the city of Shushan was glad and joyful."

"And to the sinner" — this is Haman.

"To gather" — money.

"And to amass" — *Peirush*: even more. And this is what Achashverosh gathered.

"To give" — two givings: one to Esther, and afterwards to Mordechai, who is "good before God."

(2) And the King removed — *Peirush*: He gave him two things that Haman had: his greatness in money and his greatness in honor. He gave him the house of Haman—this is his money; and the ring—this is honor. And this is "to give to him who is good before God," which is the meaning of the *Remez* (allusion) of the GRA.

(3) And Esther spoke yet again — *Peirush*: Since the King understood that "we are sold, I and my people," therefore it is written here "And Esther spoke yet again."

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Interpretation)

[On Verse 3] — And she spoke, and she fell, and she wept. This corresponds to the [four] levels of the world.

"And she wept" — this is the level of the heart, for there is no weeping except in the heart, as it says in the Zohar: "The tears are from the heart and the mind." And all of this is the language of supplication, as it says: "And she besought him," and as it says: "Do not make your prayer a fixed task, but rather mercy and supplications before the Omnipresent" (Avot 2:13).

"And she spoke yet again" — this is an addition to the [spiritual] life, as it says in *Tikkunei Zohar* (Tikkun 69).

"For we are sold" — this corresponds to the night of the Seder.

"The King's wrath" — this is the wine of the world to come, as it says: "From the wine of the spiced wine."

"To the palace garden" — this is *Gan Eden* (Paradise).

"And the King's wrath was stilled" — through the sacrifices, where the wrath is turned from judgment to mercy.

"And Esther spoke yet again" — this corresponds to the *Pesukei D'Zimrah* (Verses of Praise).

"And she spoke" — this is the *Krias Shema* (Recitation of the Shema), as it says: "And God spoke all these words, etc." and in the *Krias Shema* are all the Ten Commandments, as mentioned in the Jerusalem Talmud.

"And she fell" — this is *Nefilat Apayim* (Prostration), even though it is after the prayer, the level of it is before the prayer in *Berachot* 10b, and as it says in Zohar Bereishit (41a) that all of it is the "unification."

"And she wept" — this is the *Amidah* prayer, for there one needs intention of the heart, and the essence of intention is with tears, as mentioned above.

"And she besought him" — these are the supplications after the prayer, which are all the requests for the *Yesod* (Foundation). And the essence of the prayers is to "guard my tongue from evil, etc." which is the essence of the "He," for the four "Master of the world" [invocations] are against Idolatry, Forbidden Relations, Bloodshed, and Lashon Hara (Evil Speech), which is greater than them all. Therefore, they instituted at the beginning "guard my tongue from evil" and afterwards "and to those who curse me, let my soul be silent." And this is the meaning of "the evil of Haman," which is *Lashon Hara*, and "his

thought," which is against "and to those who curse me, let my soul be silent."

And so too on Yom Kippur at the beginning of the prayer, we pray for the Shechinah (Divine Presence) to return to its place, and in the *Kedushah* we pray… [The text here refers to mystical intentions regarding the letters of the Divine Name and the nullification of the "evil thought" of the adversary].

(4) And Esther arose — This is the ascent after *Nefilat Apayim*.

And she stood — This is the *Kedushah D'Sidra* [U'va LeTziyon], for upon it the whole world stands, as the Sages said: "On what does the world stand? On the *Kedushah D'Sidra*" (Sotah 49a).

(5) And she said, etc. — This is the prayer that follows it.

If it please the King, etc. — For every matter requires three things: 1) The will of the one being asked, 2) That the requester find favor in his eyes, and 3) That the matter itself be fit to be done. Therefore she said these three things. And she also said: "And I be good in his eyes," *Peirush*: what is his desire to benefit her, for she would be able to eat, etc. And these four things correspond to the letters of the Name *Y-H-V-H*. Therefore she said "to the King" twice, and the fourth is "and I be good in his eyes." And corresponding to them are those four things mentioned in the Gemara: "Where is Esther mentioned in the Torah? etc." (Chullin 139b).

(6) For how can I endure, etc. — *Peirush*: For there are two evil qualities: 1) That a person stands in "emptiness," which is "vanity and void," and 2) That a "righteous man perishes in his righteousness" [Ecclesiastes 7:15], for he learns all his days and it is all in vain. And regarding this we pray: "Do not withhold the righteous," meaning against one who learns in "emptiness" [with ulterior motives], which is "evil." "And do not let him stumble" is against one who learns with good thought but afterwards falls and is lost. And "the evil that shall come upon my people" is against "do not withhold the righteous," and "the destruction of my kindred" [is against the second].

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 7

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther

Chapter 7

(1) To drink with Esther the Queen — Because at the first banquet Esther was not [drinking], since she was in a state of fasting; but now she was [drinking]. Therefore, it says "with Esther the Queen."

(2) What is your petition… and what is your request — *The explanation is:* "What is your petition" refers to yourself, and "what is your request" refers to others, and it shall be done.

(3) If I have found favor in your eyes, O King, and if it please the King — *The explanation is:* A petitioner requires two things: 1) That it be the will of the giver, and 2) That the petitioner find favor in his eyes to give to him. This is the meaning of "If I have found favor," and "If it please the King," which refers to the will of the giver. **My life at my petition and my people at my request** — *The explanation is:* "My petition" is for myself, that he give me my life. "My request" for others is "my people."

(4) For we have been sold, I and my people — She said "we have been sold" because Achashverosh gave the Jews into Haman's hand through the legal mechanism of a sale, *as it says:* "The silver is given to you" (Esther 3:11). *The explanation is:* It was given as a gift, and he did not say "it is forgiven to you [the price of the Jews]," but rather "I give you the silver as if I have already received payment [for the sale of the Jews]." This is why she said, "For we have been sold, I and my people." **And had we been sold for bondmen…** — She said two things corresponding to "If I have found favor" and "If it please the King." *The explanation is:* "If I have found favor," have mercy on me, "for we have been sold, I and my people." Furthermore, it must be the "will of the giver" (the King), "for the adversary is not equal to the damage of the King." *The explanation is:* [The gain from the sale] does

not equal the damage caused to the King.

(5) Who is he, and where is he… — *The explanation is:* "Who is he" whose heart has filled him to take the Queen? "And where is he" refers to her people, for it was difficult for him—did she not say she did not know her people? "Who is he" is like the verse "Who that was innocent ever perished? And where were the upright cut off?" (Job 4:7).

(6) And Esther said… — In the *Gemara* (Megillah 16a) they said that she pointed toward Achashverosh, and an angel came and struck her hand toward Haman. This is a great wonder: for what purpose would she point her hand toward Achashverosh? It appears that because the Sages said the power of the *dimyon* (imagination/subconscious) leaves an impression on a person—as we see one who intends to call out "Shimon" but calls "Reuven" because in his thoughts it was Reuven. Know that with all the *Tzaddikim* (righteous ones), it was their way that when they spoke words before a king, their hearts and thoughts were cleaved to the Holy One, Blessed be He, *as it says:* "My lord, may the dream be for your enemies…" (Daniel 4:16) [referring to God]. So too with Nehemiah (2:4): "For what do you request? So I prayed [to the God of Heaven]…" So it was here; in her heart, she was [addressing] the Holy One, Blessed be He, but in her thought, she was on Achashverosh [the earthly king], and due to this *dimyon* she erred and pointed her hand toward Achashverosh. Then an angel came and struck her hand toward Haman.

And Haman was terrified before the King and the Queen — *The explanation is:* Before her, he could have said he did not know they were her family. Before the King, he could have said the truth—that they are her people, but they are evil, *as it says* [in his original slander]. But before both of them, he had no excuse at all. For how could he say before the Queen that they are evil? And how could he say to the King that he didn't know they were her people, when he had told the King they were evil and it was just to kill them?

(7) To the palace garden — In the *Gemara* (Megillah 16a) they said he saw ministering angels who appeared to him as men [uprooting the trees]. This is because since Haman slandered Israel with lies and vanity, the Holy One, Blessed be He, acted with him as He did with

Pharaoh, *as it says:* "And they despoiled Egypt" (Exodus 12:36), and so too with Laban. *As it says:* "For the Lord is upright, my Rock, and there is no injustice in Him" (Psalms 92:16). *The explanation is:* The Holy One, Blessed be He, is upright; and what you sometimes see—that He acts with what seems like injustice, as here, and in Egypt, and with Laban—"there is no injustice in Him," meaning no great injustice, but rather they already acted [wickedly] and are deserving of this, for the Holy One, Blessed be He, exacts punishment from them *middah keneged middah* (measure for measure).

And Haman stood up — *The explanation is:* When the King left, he stood to beg for his life, as mentioned above, and he excused himself with the aforementioned excuse.

(8) And Haman was falling — *The explanation is:* According to the *Peshat* (plain meaning), due to the greatness of his distress, he was unable to stand and fell. **Will he even conquer the Queen…** — *The explanation is:* Because [the King] thought Haman wanted to kill the Queen, and now seeing him falling, he thought he wanted to kill her in his [the King's] own house. **And Haman's face was covered** — *The explanation is:* He was ashamed, for he could not answer that he was begging her for his life—for why should he beg? Did he not say that from the perspective of justice they should be killed, as mentioned above?

(9) One of the chamberlains — In the *Gemara* (Megillah 16a) they said Charvonah was also in that [Haman's] conspiracy. *The explanation is:* Since he was among the King's chamberlains who stand before him always, how did he know [about the gallows]? Perforce, he was in that conspiracy. *The explanation is:* He was among those sent after Haman to bring him to the banquet she made, *as it says:* "The King's chamberlains arrived and hurried [to bring Haman]" (Esther 6:14), and therefore he knew. **Also, behold the gallows** — *The explanation is:* This is the gallows that he [Haman] showed him, as mentioned above. **Who spoke good for the King** — It was a cause from Hashem that he should speak in this language, so that Achashverosh would think Haman said that it [the gallows] was "better for the King" [than for Mordechai].

(10) And the King's wrath subsided — And they [the Sages] said:

[The wrath of the] King of the Universe. This is because "The King," when mentioned without qualification, refers to the Holy One, Blessed be He.

Chapter 8

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Interpretation)

(3) And Esther spoke again… and fell… and wept — This corresponds to the [four] worlds. "And she wept" corresponds to the heart, *as it says in the Zohar:* "Tears come from the heart and the mind." All of this is the language of supplications, as it says "and she beseeched him," and *as it says:* "Do not make your prayer a fixed task, but rather mercy and supplications before the Omnipresent" (Avot 2:13). "And Esther added" refers to an addition of life… **For we have been sold** — This refers to the "night" of the exile. The "banquet" is the World to Come, *as it says:* "From the wine that is preserved [from the six days of creation]." **To the palace garden** — This is the Garden of Eden. **And the King's wrath subsided** — Through the sacrifices that turn away anger. **And Esther added** — This refers to the *Pesukei D'Zimra* (Verses of Praise). **And she spoke** — This is the *Krias Shema* (Recitation of the Shema), *as it says:* "And God spoke all these words" (Exodus 20:1). In the *Shema*, all Ten Commandments are included, as mentioned in the Jerusalem Talmud (Berakhot 1:5). **And she fell** — This is *Nefilat Apayim* (the prostration prayer). Although it follows the *Amidah*, in thought it precedes the prayer, as mentioned in the *Zohar* (I:44a). **And she wept** — This is the prayer itself, for there one needs *kavanat halev* (intention of the heart), and the essence of intention is in tears. **And she beseeched him** — With the supplications after the prayer, which are the requests for the *Yesod* [the sefirah of Foundation]. The essence of the prayers is to be saved from the *Lashon Hara* (evil tongue) of the *Sitra Achra* (the Other Side), which is the root of the four primary sins: Idolatry, Forbidden Relations, Murder, and *Lashon Hara* which is greater than them all. Therefore, we established at the beginning [of the Amidah's conclusion]: "Guard my tongue from evil," and after-

ward "and to those who curse me, let my soul be silent." This is the meaning of "the evil of Haman," which is the "Evil Tongue," and "his thought," which is against "and frustrate his thought."

(4) And Esther arose — This is the ascent after *Nefilat Apayim*. **And she stood** — This is the *Kedusha D'Sidra* (the "Uva L'Tzion" prayer), for upon it the world stands, as the Sages said (Sotah 49a): "On what does the world stand? On the *Kedusha D'Sidra*."

(5) And she said… — This is the prayer of the *Ashrei* [the final prayers]. **If it please the King…** — For every matter requires three things: 1) The will of the giver, 2) That the petitioner find favor in his eyes, and 3) That the matter itself be fitting to be done. Therefore she said these three things. And she also said "and I be pleasing in his eyes," meaning what is his desire to do for her. These four phrases correspond to the four letters of the Name *Y-H-V-H*. Therefore she said "The King" twice, and the fourth is "and I be pleasing in his eyes." Corresponding to these are the four things the Gemara (Chullin 139b) says: "Where is Esther in the Torah? Where is Haman?…"

(6) For how can I endure… — *The explanation is:* There are two evil traits. One is when a person stands in "futility," which is "vanity and emptiness" [referring to wasted potential]. The second is when a person learns all his days but it is "empty vanity." Regarding this we pray "do not withhold the righteous," which is against the "evil" of learning for ulterior motives. "And do not let him fail" is against one who learns with good intention but then falls into sin and loses it all. "The evil that will find my people" is against "do not withhold the righteous," and "the destruction of my kindred" [is against the second trait].

Peshat (Plain Meaning)

(7) And to Mordechai the Jew — To Esther he spoke [privately], but he was obligated to tell Mordechai as well because he was the one who would need to implement the writing. Therefore he said "and to Mordechai the Jew."

(8) And you, write… — *The explanation is:* He said to them that they should take counsel among themselves and write concerning the Jews as they saw fit. For the [first] letters could not be revoked, *as it says:*

"For a writing which is written… cannot be revoked." Therefore, they wrote that the Jews should kill their enemies. The first letters were not revoked, but they were only implemented according to their literal text: that they should "be ready for this day." They wrote that they should be ready *to defend themselves*. If they had written in Haman's name, the people would not have paid attention; therefore they wrote to the satraps, for the "fear of Mordechai" was upon them.

(9) In the third month… on the twenty-third day — They waited so as to be certain of the speed of the couriers themselves, so people wouldn't say it was a lie. They waited until the first messengers arrived [at their destinations] and then sent these. Furthermore, they waited seventy days corresponding to the seventy years of the Babylonian exile, for this was the end of the exile. **From Hodu to Kush** — *The explanation is:* He sent to all the provinces to publicize the matter. **Every province according to its script** — *The explanation is:* As mentioned above (3:13), the script follows the province and the language follows the nation.

(10) On horses, riders of the swift steeds — *The explanation is:* So that they would not be delayed on the road more than necessary.

(11) To destroy… — *The explanation is:* They wrote this because it was written in the first letters, as mentioned above. Since they could not cancel the first letters, they added what was not written: *who* was to be ready. They clarified that the Jews were the ones to be ready, and therefore they also wrote "to destroy" [the enemies].

(12) On one day — They chose the same day so that they would have help from everyone. What they wrote—"children and women and their spoil for a prey"—was all to cancel the [effect of] the first letters, but in truth they did not want this, for it was enough for them to be saved from such a great tragedy.

(13) The copy of the writing — *The explanation is:* To the satraps he sent a detailed letter, but the "copy" (the public proclamation) was like the first one, only clarifying that the Jews should be ready.

(14) Hurried and pressed — *The explanation is:* They hurried them so that the enemies would not know what this was and would not have time to plot.

(15) And Mordechai went out… in royal apparel — "Royal ap-

parel" refers to the *Tallit* of *Mitzvah*, as it says in the *Zohar*: "The wrapping of the Kingship." **Blue (*Techelet*)** is the blue thread of the *Tzitzit*. **White (*Chur*)** is the white thread of the *Tzitzit*. **A great crown of gold** refers to the *Tefillin* on the head. **A wrap of fine linen** refers to the straps that are wrapped. **Purple (*Argaman*)** refers to the *Tefillin* of the hand, for from the "arms of man" comes the *Tefillin* of the hand, which has four levels.

(16) The Jews had light and gladness… — *The explanation is:* Israel requires the "Sign of the Covenant," which is Circumcision (*Milah*), and the "Sign" of *Tefillin*. The Torah is the intermediary, and the Sabbath itself is a "Sign." **Light** is Torah. **Gladness** is the Festivals, corresponding to the Sign of the Sabbath. **Joy (*Sasson*)** is Circumcision. **Honor (*Yikar*)** is *Tefillin*. Torah includes them all, therefore the first letters of these [four Hebrew words] are the numerical value of "Torah" (611) plus the word itself [the *kollel*]. He says "gladness and joy" because joy follows gladness… In this world, one pursues gladness to reach joy. But in the future, after they reach joy, they will still pursue gladness.

Chapter 9

(1) Which the enemies of the Jews hoped… — The Sages said: One who wants to do evil to another, that evil falls upon himself. They "hoped" to rule, but it was overturned. They ruled even over their "haters" (*shoneihem*). The Sages said "haters" refers to the guardian angels of the nations who were against Israel.

(2) For the fear of them fell upon all the peoples — But… **(3) And all the officials…** — They knew the greatness of Mordechai and feared him because he was second to the King. **Exalted the Jews** — *The explanation is:* They honored the Jews.

(4) And his fame spread… for the man Mordechai grew more and more — *The explanation is:* His fame spread throughout the world. It says "grew more and more" (*holech v'gadol*); the Jerusalem Talmud says that *Tzaddikim* grow little by little until they become great, like

the morning light that starts small and increases until the day is established.

(5) A stroke of the sword, and slaughter, and destruction — *The explanation is:* They struck them first in a place where they would not die immediately, to show them the "stroke" of the Jews. Afterward "slaughter," and afterward "destruction" of the bodies, so the gentiles would see and be afraid forever. **And did with their haters as they willed** — *The explanation is:* Just as the enemies wanted to see the Jews [destroyed], now the Jews saw their vengeance.

(10) The ten sons of Haman — These are ten names… **But on the spoil they laid not their hand** — [To show it was not for monetary gain].

(12) In Shushan the capital… what have they done in the rest of the King's provinces? — [The King asks Esther:] If they killed 500 in the capital, imagine how many they killed elsewhere! **What is your petition… and what is your request further** — [Repeating his offer of support].

(13) Let it be given to the Jews… to do tomorrow also — Esther asks for an extra day in Shushan to finish the work. **And let Haman's ten sons be hanged** — Though already dead, she asks they be hanged publicly for deterrence.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 8

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther: Chapter 8

Section 1: The Plain Interpretation (Peshat)

(1) On that day — For *Yomim Tovim* (holidays) are like single days, as it is said: "And they seemed to him but a few days [*yamim achadim*]" (Genesis 29:20). Therefore, it writes here "on that day" [singular]. However, regarding the time when there was still distress, it is written "And it was in the days of" (Esther 1:1) and "In those days" (ibid. 1:2).

This is because the *Sitra Achra* (Other Side/Evil) exists in a state of separation [and thus plural].

The King gave etc. — As it is said: "For to the man who is good before Him, He gives wisdom, knowledge, and joy; but to the sinner He gives the task of gathering and collecting, to give to him who is good before God" (Ecclesiastes 2:26). The Gemara says (Megillah 10b) that this refers to Mordechai, as it is said: "seeking the good of his people" (Esther 10:3). This is why it says "to him who is good before God," for this occurred afterward; therefore, it was "good before Him," for before the Holy One, Blessed be He, he is good.

"He gave wisdom" — to Mordechai, who is the "head of all spices" [referring to the Targum on *Mor Deror*], and it is written: "the fragrance of your oils is better than all spices" (Song of Songs 4:10). Oil represents wisdom, as our Sages of blessed memory said: "Tekoa is the alpha for oil" (Menachot 85b), and therefore Joab sent for a [wise] woman from Tekoa.

"And knowledge" — as it is said: "And the matter became known to Mordechai" (Esther 2:22), which was through *Ruach HaKodesh* (Divine Inspiration).

"And joy" — as it is said: "And the city of Shushan shouted and was glad" (Esther 8:15).

"And to the sinner" — this is Haman.

"To gather" — money.

"And to collect" — meaning even more, referring to how Ahasuerus promoted him.

"To give" — two givings: one to Esther, and afterward to Mordechai, who is "good before God."

(2) And the King removed — The explanation is: He gave him the two things Haman had: his greatness in wealth and his elevation in honor. He gave him "the house of Haman"—this is his wealth; and "the signet ring"—this is the honor. This is the meaning of "to give to him who is good before God," which consists of two gifts as mentioned above.

(3) And Esther spoke yet again — The explanation is: Initially she had said, "For we have been sold, I and my people" (Esther 7:4); therefore it writes here "And Esther spoke yet again etc."

And she spoke, and she fell, and she wept — These correspond to Thought, Speech, and Action. "And she wept" is Thought, for weeping is only in the heart, as they said in the Zohar (Zohar Chadash, Ruth 96b): "For tears go to the heart and the will." All of this is the language of supplication, as it says "and she beseeched Him." This is as the Sages said (Avot 2:13): "Do not make your prayer a fixed task, but rather [an expression of] mercy and supplication before the Omnipresent."

Section 2: The Allegorical Interpretation (Remez)

"And Esther added" — This refers to an addition of *Ruach HaKodesh*, as they said in Tikkunei Zohar (Tikkun 69, 109b) on the verse "And she added to give birth to his brother" etc. This builds upon what was said earlier: "And Esther clothed herself in royalty" (Esther 5:1), meaning she clothed herself in *Ruach HaKodesh*.

"For we have been sold" — (See Zohar II:196a) This occurred in the first half of the night.

"From the banquet of wine" — This refers to *Olam HaZeh* (this world), as it says: "from the spiced wine" (Song of Songs 8:2).

"To the garden of the pavilion" — This is *Gan Eden* (Paradise).

"And the King's wrath subsided" — Through the sacrifices, which transformed "fierce anger" into "a pleasing aroma."

"And Esther added" — This corresponds to *Pesukei D'Zimrah* (Verses of Praise).

"And she spoke" — This is *Krias Shema* (the Recitation of the Shema), as it says: "And God spoke all these words" (Exodus 20:1), and in the Shema, all Ten Commandments are hinted at, as said in the Jerusalem Talmud (Berachot 1:5).

"And she fell" — This is *Nefilat Apayim* (the supplicatory prostration). Even though this occurs after the *Amidah* prayer, the Thought [behind it] precedes the prayer during the blessings of the Shema, as said in the Zohar (Bereishit 45a) that here is the prostration.

"And she wept" — This is the *Amidah* prayer, for there one requires *kavanat halev* (intention of the heart), and the essence of intention is through tears, as I wrote above.

"And she beseeched Him" — This refers to the supplications after the prayer where all individual requests are made. The essence of these prayers is "Guard my tongue from evil" etc., which is the primary focus. For there are four primary sins: Idolatry, Forbidden Relations, Bloodshed, and *Lashon Hara* (Evil Speech), which is greater than them all. Therefore, they instituted at the beginning [of the concluding supplications] "Guard my tongue from evil," and afterward at the conclusion, "and frustrate their designs."

This is the meaning of **"the evil of Haman"** — which refers to *Lashon Hara*. **"And his plot"** — this corresponds to "frustrate their designs." Similarly, in the eighteen blessings of the prayer (*Amidah*), we pray "Return us to Your Torah," and at the conclusion we pray "and to Jerusalem" etc. The explanation is: The desire of the *yetzer hara* (evil inclination) is to make man sin so that he will not have a portion in *Olam HaBa* (the World to Come). This is [the connection between] "Return us" and "Jerusalem." Thus, "the evil" refers to causing sin, and "his plot" refers to his intent that man should not have the World to Come.

"Against the Jews" — For he [the *yetzer hara*] stands only against the Jews to make them sin.

(4) And Esther rose — This is the *Ashrei* prayer said after *Nefilat Apayim*.

"And she stood" — This is the *Kedusha D'Sidra* (the "U'va LeTzion" prayer), for upon this the whole world stands, as our Sages of blessed memory said (Sotah 49a): "Upon what does the world stand? Upon the *Kedusha D'Sidra*."

(5) And she said etc. — This is the prayer that follows it, as will be explained later, God willing.

"If it please the King…" — For in every matter, three things are required: 1) The will of the petitioner, 2) That the petitioner find favor in his eyes, and 3) The matter itself must be fit to be done. Therefore, she said these three things. She also said, **"and I am good in his eyes,"** meaning if it is his will to keep them alive, for "how can I endure…" (Esther 8:6). These four things correspond to the letters of the Name *Havayah* [Y-H-V-H]. Therefore, she said "to the King" twice, and the fourth is "and I am good in his eyes." Corresponding to these are

the four reasons the Gemara gives (Chullin 139b) for "Where is Esther found in the Torah?"

(6) For how can I endure etc. — The explanation is: There are two bad traits. First, when a person learns Torah with ulterior motives (*shelo lishmah*), which is vanity and emptiness. Regarding this it says: "And your strength shall be spent in vain" (Leviticus 26:20), for he learns all his days but it is all for naught. Second, one who learns for the sake of Heaven (*lishmah*) but afterward stops learning entirely. Regarding this we pray: "We shall not labor in vain"—this is against the one who learns with bad motives; "nor bring forth for terror"—this is against the one who learns with good thoughts but afterward departs from it, which is "terror."

This is **"the evil that will befall my people"** — this corresponds to "we shall not labor in vain." **"And the destruction of my kindred"** — this corresponds to "nor bring forth for terror." These also correspond to "the evil of Haman" (to cause sin in this world) and "his plot" (that they should not have the World to Come), as I wrote above. She said **"How"** (*Eichacha*) twice, just as it says "How (*Eichah*) do you pasture, how (*Eichah*) do you rest [the flock]" (Song of Songs 1:7), which correspond to the First Temple and the Second Temple.

Section 3: The Plain Interpretation (Continued)

(7) And to Mordechai the Jew — For to Esther alone he was afraid to say that it is impossible to revoke the decree, lest she begin to weep further. Therefore, he spoke "to Mordechai the Jew" [as well].

(8) And you, write… — The explanation is: He told them to take counsel among themselves and write concerning the Jews as you see fit. For those [original] letters cannot be revoked, for "a writing which…" (Esther 8:8). Therefore, they wrote that the Jews should kill their enemies. For they could not revoke the first letters; they only clarified the *patshegen* (transcript) of the text, which had only said "to be ready for this day." They wrote "that the Jews should be [ready]." If they had written like the wicked Haman to the common people, they would not have paid attention at all. Therefore, they wrote to the satraps, upon whom the fear of Mordechai had fallen; to them they wrote, for they would fear him.

(9) In the third month… on the twenty-third day — They waited this long so they could send the letters with the very same couriers, so people wouldn't say it was a lie [thinking], "Why should we listen to these [new ones] rather than those [old ones]?" Therefore, they waited until those messengers returned and sent the new ones back with them. Furthermore, [they waited] so that they would repent during those seventy days, corresponding to the seventy years they were in exile, and this was the end of the exile.

From India to Ethiopia — The explanation is: They sent to all the provinces to publicize the matter.

Every province according to its script — The explanation is: As I wrote above (Esther 1:22), the script follows the province and the language follows the nation.

(10) On horses, riders of swift steeds — The explanation is: So that Israel should not remain in excessive anxiety.

(11) To destroy etc. — The explanation is: They wrote this because it was written so in the first letters. As I wrote above, they could not revoke the first letters, they only clarified what was not written—who it was that was "ready." They explained that the Jews should be ready, and therefore it was also written "to destroy" [referring to the Jews destroying their enemies].

(12) On one day — Therefore they changed it and wrote that they should also plunder on that day, so that they would have helpers because of the spoil. And as for what they wrote—"children and women and to plunder their spoil"—it was all to [mirror and thus] nullify the first letters, but in truth they did not want this. For it was enough for them that they were saved from such great distress.

(13) The transcript of the writing — The explanation is: To the satraps he wrote explicitly as mentioned above. The transcript was like the first one, only they clarified that the Jews should be the ones "ready."

(14) Startled and hurried — The explanation is: They startled them so they would not know what was happening, for they gave them no rest.

(15) And Mordechai went out… in royal apparel — "Royal apparel" means the *Tallit* of the commandment, as they said in the Zo-

har (cf. III:169b), "the wrapping of the King." **"Blue"** (*Techelet*) is the blue thread of the *Tzitzit*. **"White"** (*Chur*) is the white thread of the *Tzitzit*. **"A great golden crown"** is the *Tefillin* of the head. **"A wrap of fine linen"** refers to the straps (*retzuot*) that are wrapped. **"And purple"** refers to the *Tefillin* of the hand, for from the head-Tefillin to the hand-Tefillin there are four levels.

(16) The Jews had light etc. — The explanation is: For Israel always requires "signs" (*otot*), and they are the sign of Circumcision and the sign of *Tefillin*. The Torah is the intermediary, and Shabbat itself is a sign. This is what the Sages said (Megillah 16b): "'Light' is Torah; 'Gladness' is *Yom Tov* (holidays)"—which corresponds to the sign of Shabbat; "'Joy' is Circumcision; 'Honor' is *Tefillin*." Torah includes them all; therefore, the first letters of these [four Hebrew words: *Orah, Simcha, Sasson, Yekar*] have the numerical value (*Gematria*) of "Torah" [611], and the first letters represent the essence of the whole word.

It says "Gladness and Joy" (*Simcha v'Sasson*), for *Sasson* comes after *Simcha*, as said in the Gemara (Sukkah 48b). *Simcha* is when one goes to find an object with happiness; *Sasson* is afterward when the object is already in his hand. *Sasson* is in the heart. This is the meaning of [the dialogue in the Gemara]: *Simcha* said, "I am greater than you, for it is written 'Gladness and Joy for the Jews'"; *Sasson* said, "I am greater than you, for it is written 'Joy and Gladness they shall attain'" (Isaiah 35:10). The explanation is that both are true. In this world, we pursue gladness to attain it—so gladness comes first. But *Sasson* is the object we wish to attain. However, in the future to come, God willing, after they attain *Sasson*, they will go on to attain even more *Simcha*—this is "Joy and Gladness." In the heart, *Sasson* and *Simcha* exist together, and this fits well. Both are Torah, and they are the four things mentioned above. Here was fulfilled in Mordechai "Be a lord over your brothers" (Genesis 27:29), for initially he was "a Jewish man" (*Ish Yehudi*), and afterward he was elevated to "Mordechai the Jew" (*Mordechai HaYehudi*). And Israel [is elevated] through six things: "And the city of Shushan…" and "The Jews had light…"

(17) Wherever the King's command and his decree reached — The explanation is: In the province, meaning the place where the satraps resided, the King's word itself reached them. But in the small towns

etc.

And many of the people of the land became Jews — The explanation is: For they did not accept them [as converts], as the Sages said (Yevamot 24b) that converts are not accepted in the days of Mordechai. Furthermore, they were not true converts, for they only converted out of fear. Therefore, it is written "became Jews" (*mityahadim*), meaning they made themselves look like Jews, but in truth they were not complete Jews.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 9

Commentary of the Vilna Gaon (GRA) on Megillas Esther, Chapter 9

Verses 1-2

"The enemies of the Jews hoped… they [the Jews] over their haters" (9:1): The explanation is: An "enemy" (*oyev*) is one who desires to do evil himself. A "hater" (*soneh*) is one who rejoices in the other's misfortune but does nothing himself. Therefore, regarding the "enemy," it is written that they "hoped to rule over them." **"And it was overturned":** That the Jews should rule even over their "haters." And they said **"they over their haters,"** because the forty-nine gates [of impurity] were directed toward Israel for evil, and they were all overturned to be for good, so that they would rule over their haters, for the fear of them fell upon all the peoples.

Verse 3

"And all the ministers of the provinces…": Since they knew the greatness of Mordechai, they feared him because he was the viceroy to the king. Regarding this, it says, "for the fear of Mordechai fell upon them." **"Exalted" (*menas'im*):** The explanation is: they honored the Jews.

Verse 4

"And his fame spread throughout all the provinces, for the man Mordechai grew greater and greater": The explanation is: they heard throughout the entire world that he was growing greater. It says **"grew greater and greater"** (*holech ve-gadol*) because they said in the Jerusalem Talmud that the honor of the righteous increases little by little until it becomes very great, as it says, "The path of the righteous is like the light of dawn" (Proverbs 4:18)—just as light moves and expands until midday, so it is with the righteous.

Verse 5

"A stroke of the sword, and slaughter, and destruction": The explanation is: they first struck them in a place that would not cause immediate death, in order to increase their suffering; afterward they slaughtered them; and afterward they destroyed the bodies so that the gentiles would not see them and remember [their kin] forever. **"And they did with their haters as they willed":** The explanation is: just as it was the [enemies'] will to see [evil] in the Jews at first, now the Jews saw their vengeance as their enemies were killed.

Verse 10

"The ten sons of Haman": These are ten names belonging to the *kelipot* [husks/forces of impurity] of the *Sitra Achra* (the Other Side) that were struck at the Sea, as they said in the Song of the Sea (see *Tikkunei Zohar* 21:58a). Their letters are found here [in the names of the ten sons], and the tenth includes them all; therefore, the letter *Vav* [in the name *Vayizatha*] is elongated (*Vav Arich*). They are the [letter] *Heh* which includes fifty (*Nun*); this is the numerical value of "Haman." The *Heh* from here onward also includes fifty, and so too in the prayer [the *Amidah*], as it says, "with signs…" (Deuteronomy 26:8). This is the secret of what they said: that the Egyptians were struck with fifty plagues. This is also why Rabbi Eliezer and Rabbi Akiva disagreed (in the Passover Haggadah) regarding "From where do we know that every plague…": one counted the particulars and the other counted the general categories as well. This is what they said in the Gemara: that with the first "sign" they were struck in Egypt, and with the sec-

ond "sign" they were struck at the Sea, and all of them are included in the final "sign." They were all struck with the "Staff," for it includes everything and consists of three matters: this staff which was overturned (*hafach*) and is called the "Staff of the Female" (*Matteh Nukva*). Similarly, "ten" includes thirty letters, corresponding to the thirty-one kings of Canaan. This is the meaning of what they said (Megillah 16b): "All the songs [in Scripture] are written 'a half-brick over a whole brick' except for this one and the song of the [kings of] Canaan." This is also what they said (Mechilta, Exodus 20:1): "'I am [the L-rd]' and 'You shall not have [other gods]' were said in a single utterance," for the thirty-one paths are doubled in the secret of "the Glory of G-d" (*Kevod El*), whose "Kingdom rules over all," which is why there are ten, corresponding to the numerical value of *Malchut* (Kingdom). **"But on the spoils they did not lay their hand":** In order to show that they did not act for the sake of money, but only to fulfill the decree of the King.

Verse 13

"Let it be granted also tomorrow": They did this so that they would be feared by the ministers, lest they say that at first Haman deceived Mordechai and now Mordechai deceived Haman, and it was not by the King's command, for the King knows nothing of it. Therefore, she requested that even what was not written at all in the letter should be done. Also, they would see that even great ministers were hanged, and this was by the King's command, for this was not written in the law; thus, they must have done this by the King's command, and they would not have hatred toward the Jews even afterward.

Verse 16

"And stood": The explanation is: in complete unity. **"For their lives":** Lest the enemies come upon them. **"And had rest from their enemies":** For they [the enemies] did not come at all and went away. **"And slew among their haters":** The explanation is: because the enemies did not come [to attack], they [the Jews] went and slew among their haters.

Verse 17

"And made it a day of feasting and gladness": For on the 13th day they were in great distress, fearing that [the enemies] might stand against them and kill them; but now that no man stood before them, they made a feast.

Verse 19

"Therefore the Jews of the villages, who dwell in the unwalled towns": The explanation is: they distinguished between the walled cities and the unwalled towns because Esther requested that they kill in Shushan also on the 14th because they feared the ministers who saw the two letters. Therefore, they innovated an additional day there that was not written originally, to show that it was the King's command and they did not act on their own, for the 14th day was not written in the letters; thus, it was explicitly from the King. However, they did not fear the common people at all, for they thought it was like that from the beginning and they only "corrected" it as mentioned above. The ministers dwell in the province that is surrounded by a wall; therefore, all walled cities needed this—to kill in Shushan also on the 14th—so they also act like Shushan. But in the unwalled towns where the ministers do not dwell, the main miracle was on the 14th. The reason they linked it to Joshua son of Nun is because, as I have already written, although Sennacherib exiled all the nations, the "Equal Ones" [the original inhabitants] remained in their places, and the dwelling of the ministers originally from the time they entered the Land of Israel—the nations also settled on their land then. Therefore, they linked the time of the walled cities to the days of Joshua son of Nun, for then the displacement of the "Equal Ones" began. **"Gladness, and feasting, and a holiday, and sending portions…":** These four correspond to the four things Haman wanted to do, as mentioned above (3:13).

Verse 20

"These things": The explanation is: as it says later, "to establish upon them."

Verse 21

"The day of…": The explanation is: as our Rabbis of blessed memory said (Megillah 5b), [it was only necessary] to forbid the [celebration] of this one on the [day of] that one.

Verse 22

"And the month which was overturned…": The explanation is: when one sits in distress, as was the case here, thinking that in that month trouble will come—once that [month] arrives, they are in even greater distress. Therefore, it says "the month was overturned," for the entire month was overturned from grief to joy. This is what they said in the Gemara (Taanit 29a): "Just as when Av enters we diminish joy, so when Adar enters we increase joy." At first glance, it is difficult to see how these relate to each other, but according to what I have written, it works well: just as when Av enters we diminish joy because the entire month was in grief, so in Adar the entire month was overturned to joy, as mentioned.

Verse 23

"And the Jews accepted": The explanation is: they all accepted as one. **"That which they had begun to do…":** The explanation is: as it is written, "and made it a day of feasting and gladness." **"And that which [Mordechai] wrote…":** Namely, the sending of portions and gifts to the poor.

Verse 24

"For Haman…": The explanation is: this was all written in the book. Until "Therefore, because of all the words of this letter," it is the reason for the letter that Mordechai sent, and this is the essence of the great miracle.

Verse 25

"And when she came before the king": The explanation is: when the matter came before the king in its clarity, he said with the book, etc.

Verse 26

"After the name of the Pur": After the name of the miracle, that the Holy One, Blessed be He, overturned all the constellations (*mazalot*), which is the essence of the miracle. **"Therefore, because of all the words of this letter… and what reached them":** For there were two types among Israel. Those very far away saw nothing even at first except through the letter. At first, they did not know the matter clearly because it was not written [fully] as mentioned. But those who were closer saw the troubles of their haters, who caused them distress. This is what it means by "the words of the letter"—referring to those very far away. "And what they saw"—those who saw it explicitly. "And what reached [them]"—those who were very close.

Verse 27

"The Jews established and accepted upon themselves": Because they [the enemies] wanted to kill them. **"And upon their seed":** For they were included in the destruction. If their fathers had not existed, they would not be in the world at all, nor would there be any memory of them; therefore, their seed was included in the destruction. **"And upon all who joined them…":** For they were included in the annihilation because [the enemies] wanted to uproot the religion; if so, they too would not exist. Therefore, they also need [to observe], even though they were not included in the "killing and destroying." **"According to their writing":** This refers to the reading of the Megillah.

Verse 28

"Remembered": This is the reading of the Megillah. **"And observed":** This is the making of the feast. **"In every generation":** And who are those who observe? **"Family and family":** These are the families of the Priesthood (*Kehunah*) and Levites (*Leviyah*). **"Province and province":** Walled cities from the days of Joshua son of Nun to the days of Ahasuerus. **"And city and city":** These are the villages. A "village" is a city that does not have ten idle men [available for communal needs]. These are ten things, but the first four are the "generalities of generalities," and they correspond to the Ten Commandments; the first four correspond to "I am [the L-rd]," "You shall not have," "You shall

not murder," and "You shall not commit adultery." **"And these days of Purim… the Jews, and their memory shall not perish from their seed":** The explanation is: the days of Purim, which are the feasting and gladness, shall not pass from among the Jews, who are the adults; and "their memory," which is the reading of the Megillah, shall not perish even from their seed, for even children are obligated in the reading of the Megillah.

Verse 29

"And Esther wrote": The explanation is: they wrote the entire Megillah with *Ruach HaKodesh* (Divine Inspiration) and sent it in a letter. This is the meaning of "to establish this second letter of Purim"—the explanation is that they should read and establish what is within it. **"The second":** What they wrote in the second year after the first letters, as mentioned above.

Verse 30

"Words of peace and truth": "Words of peace" is the Megillah they sent. "Truth" is the Torah; for they accepted the Torah with great love, without any "notification" or coercion at all (Shabbat 88a). This is why they said (Megillah 16b) that it requires ruled lines (*sirtut*) like the "truth of the Torah." This is because since the Megillah is equated to the Torah, it implies that all the laws applicable to the Torah, even ruled lines, apply to it.

Verse 31

"As he established": The explanation is: as Mordechai commanded them. **"And as they established":** That Mordechai and Esther also established [upon themselves and their seed], so they all established everything upon themselves. **"And as they accepted the matters of the fasts and their cry":** Just as they were in distress [and fasted], so they now accepted the Megillah.

Verse 32

"And the decree of Esther established…": Due to the strength of Esther, the matters of Purim were established and written in the book.

For she commanded, and they were not permitted to nullify her words, as they said in the Gemara: "Esther sent [to the Sages]…" and it was established because she was a queen.

Chapter 10

Verse 2

"And all the acts of his power and his might": "Power" (*tokef*) is when everyone listens to what he says and does his bidding. "Might" (*gevurah*) is when he is a great hero, more so than his peers, but they do not necessarily do his bidding; therefore, it only writes "his power and all the acts." **"And the account of the greatness of Mordechai":** The explanation is: in the [Persian] chronicles, it only writes generalities; therefore, it says that they are written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Media and Persia. See what I wrote above (8:8) regarding Media first and then Persia.

Verse 3

"Viceroy to the King": He was so in the eyes of the world. **"And great to the Jews":** The explanation is: he was also so in their eyes because he was great in Torah. **"And accepted by the multitude of his brethren":** He possessed wisdom, as it says, "He who finds a wife finds good and obtains favor from the L-rd" (Proverbs 18:22)—"wife" refers to wisdom. As it says, "accepted by his brethren," and he was "faithful to his sender" [G-d]. Regarding "oil" [which represents wisdom], as I wrote above (8:8), Tekoa was a city of wisdom because the oil of Tekoa was used for [wisdom]. **"Seeking good":** This refers to good deeds and good character traits (*middot tovot*). Good traits are greater than everything, as it is written that those who act with good traits are praised, for they include the entire Torah. As it says, "Anyone who becomes angry is as if he worships idols," and "Anyone who denies [the duty of] kindness is like one who denies the Essence [G-d]," and so too with all of them. The reason is that [peace] is the vessel for everything. It is the vessel for all traits and the garment for all

traits. This is the meaning of "The Holy One, Blessed be He, found no vessel that holds blessing for Israel except peace" (Uktzin 3:12). This means the vessel must be able to receive the reward, and the Holy One, Blessed be He, found no one who could receive it except through peace, which is the garment for all traits. Since he directed himself toward peace, they were able to receive the Torah. This is the Priestly Blessing, which contains six blessings corresponding to the Five Books of the Torah, and the completion is against the [good] traits, and peace is the sum of all traits; therefore, it concludes with peace. For this reason, the six orders of the Mishnah also conclude with peace, for they too correspond to the six mentioned above. Therefore, the Mishnah begins with "Blessings" (*Berachot*), for peace is the *Tzaddik* (Righteous One), and "Blessings are for the head of the Tzaddik." Also, because at the beginning of the order of *Zeraim* (Seeds), you find that the *Tzaddik* is the foundation, as his seed is upon the earth, and "Blessings are for the head of the Tzaddik," therefore it begins with *Berachot*. Therefore, it also says, **"and speaking peace to all his seed."**

The essence of the matter is: "The scepter shall not depart from Judah" (Genesis 49:10). Our Sages interpreted this as the "Heads of the Exile" (*Resh Galuta*) in Babylon who rule with the scepter, and "the lawgiver from between his feet" refers to the Princes (*Nesi'im*) of the Land of Israel who teach Torah in public. Mordechai possessed both the Princedom and the Headship of the Exile. For the [Head of the Exile] is the ruler with the scepter and shepherds the nation. And the [Prince] is the one who speaks with all the people. Mordechai's mother was from the tribe of Judah and his father from the tribe of Benjamin; therefore, he attained both the Princedom and the Headship of the Exile. This is why it says "from between his feet" and not from himself. He attained all parts of excellence: judgment, wisdom, understanding, knowledge, good deeds, good traits, mercy, and giving, and the like. This is: **"For Mordechai the Jew was viceroy to King Ahasuerus"**—this is in Understanding (*Binah*), to rule with strength and to judge them, for this requires understanding, as it says, "And Pharaoh said… there is none so understanding and wise as you" (Genesis 41:39). "Wise" refers to how to gather the grain; "understanding" refers to how to judge the people. **"And great to the Jews"**—in Wis-

dom (*Chokmah*), as it says, "And he was wiser than all men" (1 Kings 5:11). **"And accepted by the multitude of his brethren"**—in Torah, as it says, "For he who finds me finds life and obtains favor from the L-rd" (Proverbs 8:35), which is in Knowledge (*Da'at*). **"Seeking good for his people"**—this is in good deeds and acts of kindness for all of Israel. **"And speaking peace to all his seed"**—for he was good to all the nations so that they would not take revenge on his seed after his death, for he spoke peace with everyone, and from this, peace reached all his seed forever. And may peace and blessing be upon us and upon all Israel forever. Amen.

With this, the commentary of the GRA, of blessed memory, is completed. Blessed be the Merciful One who assisted us.

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The Vilna Gaon — Commentary on Esther, Chapter 10

Esther Chapter 10

Verse (1): "And King Ahasuerus imposed a tax on the land and the islands of the sea." (Esther 10:1)

Peshat: A tax on the land and the islands of the sea — As I wrote above (1:1), there are one hundred [provinces] on the land and twenty-seven on the sea.

Verse (2): "And all the acts of his power and his might, and the full account of the greatness of Mordecai to which the king advanced him, are they not written in the book of the chronicles of the kings of Media and Persia?" (Esther 10:2)

Peshat: And all the acts of his power and his might — "Power" (*tokef*) refers to the fact that everyone listens to what he says and carries out his word. "Might" (*gevurah*) refers to him being a greater warrior than his fellow, yet they do not necessarily carry out his word; therefore, regarding his "power," it is written "and all the acts" [implying the execution of his will]. **And the full account of the greatness of Mordecai** — The explanation is: Here, only the generalities are written; therefore it says, "[are they not written in the book of the chroni-

cles of the kings of Media and Persia]." See what I wrote above (1:1) regarding why it mentions Media first and then Persia.

Verse (3): "For Mordecai the Jew was viceroy to King Ahasuerus, and great among the Jews, and accepted by the multitude of his brethren, seeking the good of his people and speaking peace to all his seed." (Esther 10:3)

Peshat: Viceroy to the king — This refers to matters of this world. **And great among the Jews** — The explanation is: He was also important in their eyes because he was great in Torah. **And accepted by the multitude of his brethren** — This refers to *Chokhmah* (Wisdom), as it says: "'One who has found a wife has found good and has obtained favor (*ratzon*) from Hashem' (Proverbs 18:22). 'Found' refers to a woman of valor, and 'obtained favor' refers to Wisdom." As it says: "Let him be accepted (*ratzui*) by his brothers, and let him dip his foot in oil" (Deuteronomy 33:24), and "oil" refers to Wisdom, as I wrote above (8:1) that Tekoa was the city of Wisdom because Tekoa is the primary source for oil. **Seeking good** — This refers to good deeds and good character traits (*middot*). Good character traits are greater than everything, as I wrote (Song of Songs 1:5) that good traits were not explicitly written in the Torah because they encompass the entire Torah. As the Sages said: "Anyone who becomes angry is as if he worships idols" (Rambam, *De'ot* 2:3), and "Anyone who speaks *lashon hara* (evil speech) is like one who denies the Essential Principle [G-d]" (*Sotah* 42a), and so too with all of them. **Peace** (*Shalom*) is the general vessel for all the traits and is the "garment" for all the traits. This is the meaning of what they said: "The Holy One, Blessed be He, found no vessel that could hold blessing for Israel except peace" (*Uktzin* 3:12). This means that a vessel must be able to receive everything, and the Holy One, Blessed be He, found nothing that could receive [everything] except peace, which is the garment for all the traits, and the traits are the sum total of the commandments. And He blessed them with peace so they would be able to receive the Torah. This is the meaning of the Priestly Blessing, which consists of six blessings: five corresponding to the Five Books of the Torah, and the sixth corresponding to the character traits. Peace is the sum total of all the traits; therefore, it concludes with peace. For this reason, the *Shas* (Six Orders of the Mishnah) also

concludes with peace, because they also correspond to the aforementioned six. Therefore, the Mishnah begins with *Berakhot* (Blessings), because "Peace" is the *Tzaddik* (Righteous One), and "Blessings are for the head of the *Tzaddik*" (Proverbs 10:6). Also, because initially the Order of *Zeraim* (Seeds) was taught, and "Seed" is the *Tzaddik* in the secret of "whose seed is in it upon the earth" (Genesis 1:11), and "Blessings are for the head of the *Tzaddik*"; therefore it begins with *Berakhot*. Therefore it also says, **"and speaking peace to all his seed."** The core of the matter is "The scepter shall not depart from Judah" (Genesis 49:10), which the Sages interpreted (*Sanhedrin* 5a) as "these are the Exilarchs in Babylon who rule with the scepter," and "nor the ruler's staff from between his feet," "these are the Princes (*Nesi'im*), the descendants of Hillel, who taught Torah in public." Mordecai possessed both the Princehood and the Exilarchate, for the Exilarch is the one who rules with the scepter and governs the people, while the Prince is the one who learns with all the people. Mordecai's mother was from the tribe of Judah and his father was from the tribe of Benjamin; therefore, he attained both—the Princehood and the Exilarchate. Regarding him it says "from between his feet" and not from [Judah] himself. He attained all parts of excellence, which are five: *Chokhmah* (Wisdom), *Binah* (Understanding), *Da'at* (Knowledge), good deeds, and good character traits (merciful, generous, and the like). This is the meaning of: **"For Mordecai the Jew was viceroy to King Ahasuerus."** This corresponds to *Binah*, for to rule over a people and judge them, one must have *Tevunah* (Understanding), as it says: "Now let Pharaoh look for a man of understanding (*navon*) and wisdom (*chakham*)" (Genesis 41:33). A "wise man" knows how to gather storehouses of grain; a "man of understanding" knows how to judge the people. **And great among the Jews** — In *Chokhmah*, as it says: "And that man was great (*gadol*) among all the people of the East" (Job 1:3). And it is written: "And Solomon's wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the people of the East" (I Kings 5:10), who were great sages. **And accepted by the multitude of his brethren** — In Torah, as it says: "For he who finds me finds life and obtains favor (*ratzon*) from Hashem" (Proverbs 8:35); this is in *Da'at*. **Seeking good for his people** — This refers to good deeds and acts of kindness (*gemilut chasadim*) with all of Israel. **And speak-**

ing peace to all his seed — For he would do good for all the nations so they would not take revenge on his descendants after his death; he spoke peace with everyone. From this, peace reached all his seed forever. May peace and blessing be upon us and all of Israel forever. Amen.

Remez (Allegorical/Mystical Interpretation)

Verse (1): "And King Ahasuerus imposed a tax…" (Ahasuerus) showed the "wealth of the glory of his kingdom." According to the *Targum Rishon* and the Midrash, he showed them sixty-eight [types of] treasures every day, and for 180 days, this equals 12,240 treasures, which is the number of the people of the G-d of the nation [the Jewish people]. It seems to me that the *Targum Rishon* says that when he opened [the treasures of] Media and Persia, there were 180… which is a reference to the "Beauty" (*Tiferet*) of the Name of G-d that encompasses them all. It seems to me in the collected writings of the Gra (*Likutim*), his showing [the treasures] was intended only to be in the presence of the "Last One" [referring to a specific mystical stage or personage].

Verse (5): "…in the court of the garden of the king's pavilion." It appears that "pavilion" (*bitan*) is a "house" (*bayit*) according to the Sages. It was a small royal house that he had inside the king's garden, and the garden surrounded it. We only entered the garden of the small royal house that was there. The garden and the palace are usually outside the city in a spacious place to provide air for the people.

Verse (6): "There were hangings of white, fine cotton, and blue…" Every curtain of the hangings of the garden pavilion was made of these three colors. "White" (*Chur*) refers to white linen… "Fine cotton" (*Karpas*) was green like a leek. "Blue" (*Tekhelet*) is well known. (These three colors are a sign: white is the sign of the attribute of Kindness (*Chesed*), and red [implied by other fabrics] is the sign of Judgment (*Din*) and war). **Attached with cords of fine linen and purple** — These curtains were attached to one another upon the rollers and upon the pillars with cords of fine linen and purple. (The linen was

separated from the purple so there would be no *kilayim* [forbidden mixture of wool and linen], even if the curtains were for Israelites). **Silver rollers** — These were round tubes upon which the curtains were hung, and the rollers were above. **And marble** (*Shesh*) — This is marble. It is called *shesh* [meaning six] because it has six colors… as the Sages said in the *Tanchuma* that it had six shades. **And mother-of-pearl and precious stone** (*Dar ve-socheret*) — The Gemara explains this as "rows upon rows" (*dari dari*). It appears the floor was made of rows upon rows of precious stones… and *socheret* was the border between these stones.

Verse (7): "And they gave them drink in vessels of gold, the vessels being diverse one from another…" Peshat: Because wine spoils when it stays a long time in gold vessels (*Ta'anit* 7a), the verse explains that they were changing the vessels every moment for different ones so it would not spoil. Or, the explanation is: "vessels from vessels" means additional types of vessels from various diverse types, but it mentions only the most important—the gold. **Royal wine** — Wine that is fit for a king's table… **In abundance, according to the bounty of the king** — This wine was abundant for everyone, truly a massive amount, according to the "hand of the king," for it is not the way of a king to give a small gift.

Verse (8): "And the drinking was according to the law; none did compel…" Peshat: For so the king had appointed to all the officers of his house, to do according to every man's pleasure.

[End of Commentary] With this, the commentary of the Gra, of blessed memory, is completed. Blessed is the Merciful One who assisted us.